SRI SATHYA SAI VIDYA VIHAR
5TH EDITION

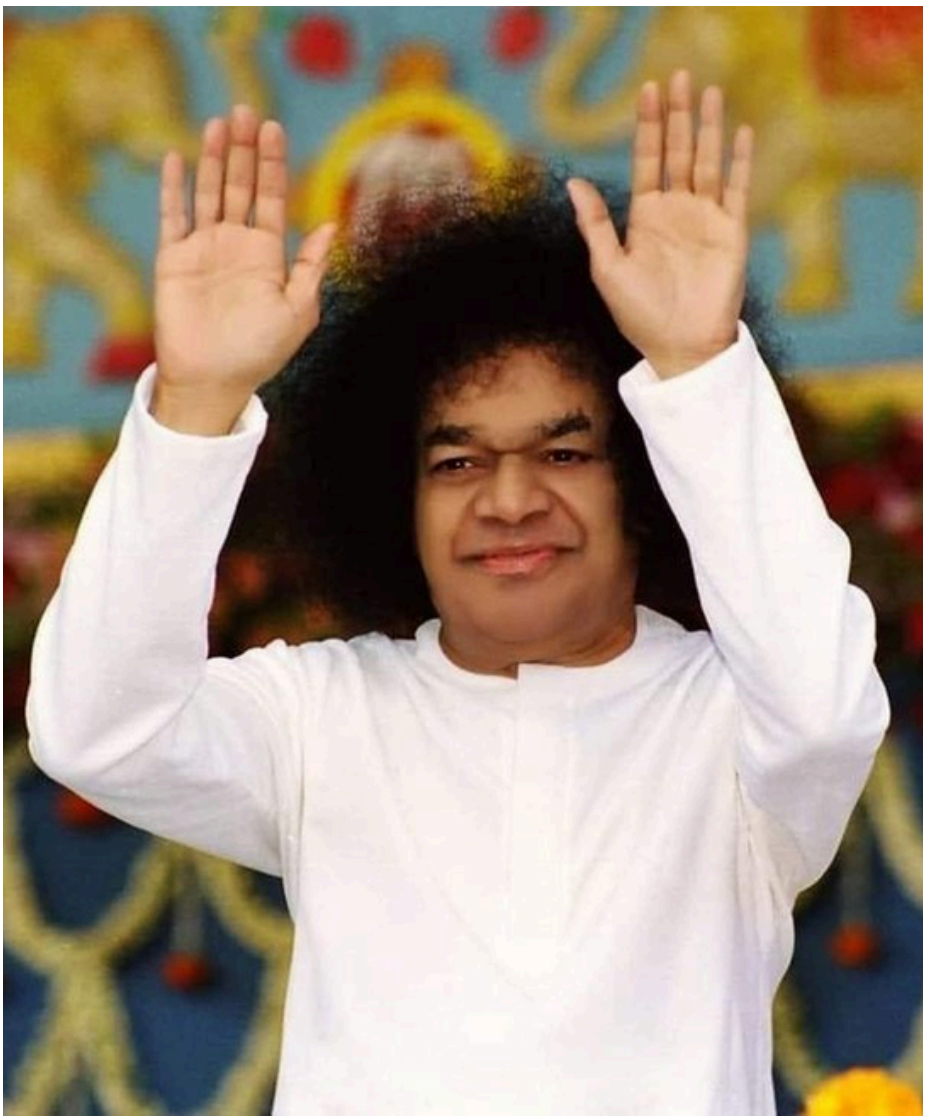
Mindscape

A journey through the science and soul of the human psyche.

The FIFA Effect - Why Football is the Biggest Sport

The People Behind the Labels - Rehabiliation Visit Experience

The Case Study of Vincent van Gogh



“THOSE ANXIOUS TO LIVE IN JOY MUST ALWAYS BE DOING GOOD”

FROM THE *Principal's* DESK

The school has always upheld an environment that fosters intellectual curiosity, collaboration and cooperation among students and I am jubilant to see the reflection of these values in the psychology magazine, Mindscape, created by our students. Mindscape is a testament to the tremendous potential and talent of our students. It brings me great joy to see all the young minds come together and form something so intellectually satisfying and creative.

As students, you are the most important asset to the future. Young minds are very impressionable and when exposed to the ideas of self, of others and of the complexities of the mind, they develop into conscious, mindful members of the society.

In a world where mental health is steadily gaining respect and recognition, Mindscape is a magazine of today — it reflects the change, the aspirations and the needs of the present society. And on this display of sensitivity and creativity, I would like to extend my hearty congratulations to the Mindscape team — the writers, the designers, the teachers and all those who helped make this vision possible.

May your compassion for the human mind continue to grow and light the path of others into building a more healthy, kind and compassionate world. I wish you all the best in your academic pursuits and hope that this magazine becomes a platform to share your creative insights.

Warm regards,
Dr. Anju Chopra
Principal

FROM THE TEACHER'S DESK

Teaching Psychology is a joy, but watching students live it is an even greater one. It fills me with immense pride to see this initiative come to life: Mindscape , our Psychology magazine.

My goal as a teacher has always been to inspire students to go beyond textbooks and grades. Psychology is not just a subject to score in exams. It is a way to understand people, to help others and to make a meaningful difference.

And that is exactly what Mindscape reflects.
In a world quick to judge and quick to label, this magazine invites you to pause. To think. To introspect. To ask why.

Mindscape is the culmination of our classroom lessons, our discussions and our shared passion to build a kinder world. It is a stepping stone for our students to grow into mindful, compassionate and responsible individuals.

A special welcome to all readers who do not study Psychology formally. This magazine is for you too. Psychology is just as fascinating in everyday life as it is on these pages, and I hope Mindscape encourages you to explore it.

Heartiest congratulations to all my students. Your love for the subject, your kindness and your enthusiasm make me incredibly proud.

Warm regards,

Priyanka Tiwari Mudgal

Teacher (Psychology)

LETTER *from the* TEAM

Dear Reader,

Welcome back to Edition 5!
Wishing a very happy Children's Day to the inner child in all of us! May this child forever flourish within you, adding moments of joy and celebration.

You will notice that subtly (or not so subtly), this edition celebrates great lives. That is why you'll spot names like Billy Eilish, Vincent van Gogh, Lionel Messi and others.

We have brought to you the case study of Vincent van Gogh—the tragedy of a talented artist. Alongside, you'll see how neurodevelopmental disorders (like ADHD, Autism and Dyslexia) rewire the brain in a way that produces astounding creativity. The movie review of *Barbie* (2023) reveals a side of the film that has deeply psychological aspects.

We proudly present to you the character analysis of Elijah Mikaelson—the vampire in a suit with a thousand years of emotional trauma and questionable decisions.

To know more about the relationship between sports and psychology, check out the articles titled *The FIFA Effect* and *Into the Mind of a Formula 1 Driver*. We have covered everyday phenomena like feeling 'butterflies in the stomach' and the experience of nostalgia in various articles.

Some of us visited a rehabilitation center some time back, the experience and learning from which is captured in a following article.

We remain steadfast in our mission of making psychology relatable, approachable and fun. This edition highlights this goal.

And so we present Edition 5 to you from the bottom of our hearts.

Read on, dear reader.

Love,
Team Mindscape

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Why is Being Stupid More Dangerous than Being Evil?

By Maira K.B Wala

Everyone of us has experienced more than once the canon event of doing or saying something stupid —whether it was in a conversation with your friends, in a debate with your sibling or even on an exam paper. Dietrich Bonhoeffer, a 20th century theologian and philosopher, argued that stupidity should be viewed as worse than evil. Does that imply we're somehow worse or more dangerous than, say, a gang of Machiavellian schemers? Definitely not. But past its face value, Bonhoeffer suggests a compelling argument for why stupidity is a bigger threat to civilisation than even evil.

What's important to understand is what Bonhoeffer even meant by "stupidity", because he actually uses the word in a different sense as compared to how we use it in our everyday lexicon. Firstly, he notes that stupidity is not the same as foolishness. Foolishness is when you do something silly or reckless. For example, pulling a door with a 'PUSH' sign on it or trying to find your phone while already holding it. Those are examples of foolishness, but they are not stupidity (per Bonhoeffer, else your choice, your view). Secondly, he notes that stupidity is also not the same as a lack of cognitive ability. Finding yourself in a situation that demands something simply beyond what you are capable of like going bowling with your friends but not being able to score a single point or not being able to drive a car are not examples of stupidity. Thirdly, stupidity is also not the same as ignorance. Ignorance is a product of either a lack of education or a lack of exposure to a fact, piece of information or knowledge about something. For example, if you don't know the laws of motion or the name of a color or the capital of Indonesia, those are examples of ignorance, but not stupidity.

So what is stupidity? Bonhoeffer defines stupidity using three elements. The first one being outsourcing our critical thinking to a third party. The third party in question may be a teacher, a friend, a parent or even technology. The most prominent one in our everyday lives being, of course, technology. A lot of people are prone to using AI tools like ChatGPT or Gemini to do their thinking for them. Even using tools like Google Maps is an example of outsourcing a critical thinking skill—navigation—to a third party (woah, genius). The second element is willful ignorance. While ignorance itself is not stupidity, not taking any steps to resolve your ignorance is an example of stupidity. For instance, not knowing how to use a basic software tool when you start a job isn't stupidity. However, using that tool every day for six months, repeatedly breaking the workflow and actively refusing to watch a 5-minute tutorial or ask for help —that is willful ignorance. Some people may even be prone to celebrating the fact that they don't know something and taking pride in it. That is a very prominent example of stupidity. The third element of stupidity according to Bonhoeffer is conformity. When people start to identify and then conform to a group, they start caring about loyalty and identity more than about the truth. For example, a die-hard sports fan watches their favorite team's player commit an

obvious, slow-motion foul on live TV. Instead of accepting the clear video evidence, the fan insists the referee rigged the game against their team. Conformity might also mean outsourcing your thinking to the group itself. For instance, a person might believe that birds are evil, not because they have evidence for it, but simply because they conform to a group which collectively agrees that it is the case that birds are evil.

Ultimately Bonhoeffer argues that stupidity is more dangerous than evil because it has a greater potential to damage our lives. A powerful idiot can cause more harm than a powerful robber. This is also made evident by the fact that evil is generally far more visible and less tolerated than stupidity is. We know when there is evil and we can deny its power. For example, we can identify a robber when we catch them stealing and the justice system can put the criminal in prison. But in the case of stupidity, not only is it not always clearly

visible, but we as a society are also more accepting of it. When a classmate proudly claims they ‘just don't get’ how to format a document or turn in an assignment online, relying on group partners to do it, we laugh it off as a harmless personality trait instead of calling out their refusal to spend 2 minutes learning.

So how do we fix that? How can we take steps to remove stupidity on a personal level, and also from society as a whole? Well the first thing to do is resolve our ignorance about the danger of stupidity, which those of you who read the article this far have already done (yeah, I am cool just like that). The next thing we can do is to train ourselves to question, scrutinize and modify our beliefs on a regular basis. We can learn to accept constructive criticism of our values and beliefs from others as well, without feeling attacked or needing to defend ourselves. This is made easier by reminding ourselves that we are not defined by a set of strict beliefs, and criticism of those beliefs is not a criticism of our character or identity. We can take a step even further and choose to wilfully seek out those who will critique our beliefs and ideas and dispute our convictions. On an interpersonal level, we can be less accepting of stupidity and take steps to not only resolve our own stupidity and ignorance, but also contribute to resolving the stupidity of those around us.

Ultimately, overcoming stupidity isn't about being the smartest person in the room but rather about being aware of how little you know and spending a lifetime trying to resolve that.

THE CHARACTER ANALYSIS OF ELIJAH MIKAELSON

By Avani Soni

**Before you begin— Dear reader, you have been warned. This is a psychological analysis of Elijah Mikaelson, not a defence attorney's brief, not a neutral assessment and certainly not a safe space for anyone who intends to remain emotionally detached. The subject has approximately a thousand years (yes, he's a vampire) of accumulated trauma, an alarming tendency to murder people in immaculate suits, an almost pathological devotion to his family and the ability to say something devastatingly profound while looking as though he has just stepped out of a luxury menswear advertisement. Any attempt to analyse him objectively may therefore be interrupted by involuntary admiration. Statistics reveal that a hundred per cent people who have gotten to know Elijah Mikaelson have developed an incurable and profound admiration (translation: obsession) for him. Proceed accordingly (and read the notes at the end).*

There is something almost perversely fascinating about Elijah Mikaelson because he is constructed around contradiction. He is one of the most cultured, articulate and self-controlled characters in *The Vampire Diaries* and *The Originals*, yet he is also capable of extraordinary violence; he speaks constantly about morality while repeatedly violating it; he presents himself as the guardian of his family while sometimes becoming its most dangerous weapon; and he spends centuries attempting to preserve the people he loves even when those people repeatedly make that love almost impossible.

Elijah is not simply 'the good Mikaelson'. That interpretation is much too convenient. He is better understood as a man whose identity has been organised around responsibility, loyalty, self-sacrifice, emotional suppression and an almost compulsive need to maintain order in a family whose history is essentially one enormous psychological emergency. His greatest virtue and his greatest weakness are, in fact, the same thing: he cannot stop believing that he is responsible for everyone he loves.

That is what makes Elijah psychologically compelling. His polished manners are not merely personality traits; they are part of his psychological architecture. His suits, measured speech, rituals of civility and remarkable composure create an external structure around an internal world that is considerably more chaotic.

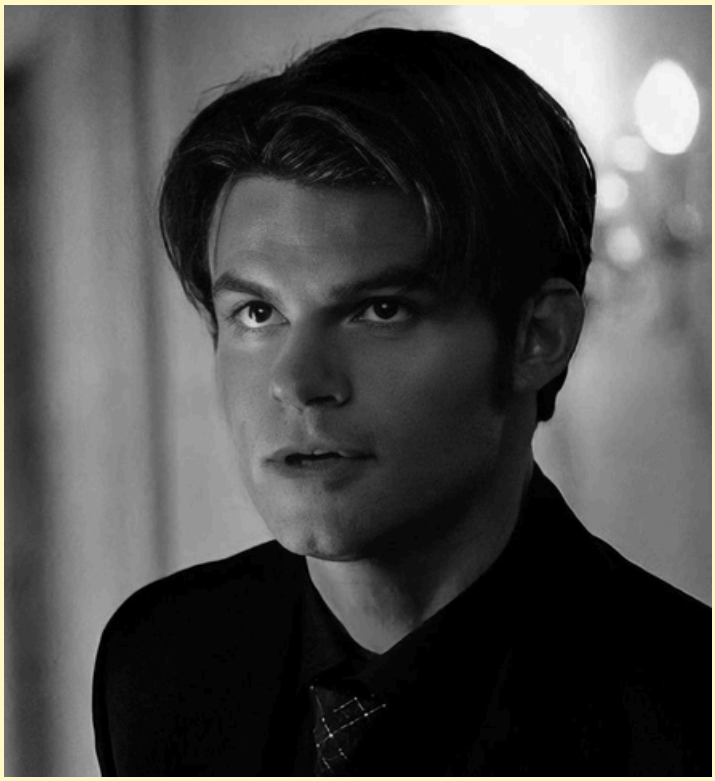
Elijah has spent centuries constructing himself into the man who can remain standing when everyone else falls apart. If Klaus (his younger brother) is the storm, Elijah becomes the person who walks into the storm carrying an umbrella, a first-aid kit, a legal document and somehow still manages to look devastatingly handsome (whoops). His refinement therefore functions partly as *emotional regulation* and partly as *identity construction*. He has decided who he must be and then he disciplines himself relentlessly into becoming that person.

Before the Suit, There Was the Boy

To understand Elijah, we have to go back before the Original vampires, before the centuries of murder, before the famous suits and the even more famous family motto (it's "always and forever", BTW). Elijah was born into a profoundly *dysfunctional* family in a dangerous historical environment, the son of Mikael and Esther. His childhood was marked by instability, violence, fear and most importantly, a complicated family hierarchy in which strength became synonymous with survival. Mikael was authoritarian, demanding and often cruel, while Esther's affection existed within a family structure that repeatedly exposed her children to danger. The Mikaelsons did not grow up with the psychological luxury of ordinary childhood development. Their world taught them that survival depended on family cohesion, strength and vigilance.
Within that environment, Elijah appears to have developed a strong *parentification* dynamic.

Parentification occurs when a child assumes responsibilities that developmentally belong to the adults around them, becoming a caretaker, mediator or stabilising figure within the family. Elijah repeatedly occupies precisely this role. He becomes one of the siblings who attempts to maintain order, particularly in relation to Klaus. Instead of simply being Klaus's brother, Elijah gradually becomes something closer to his protector, mediator, moral guide and emotional regulator. This is significant because the psychological relationship between the brothers is not simply one of affection. Elijah's identity becomes intertwined with Klaus's survival.

That is where attachment theory becomes particularly useful. Elijah's relationship with Klaus reflects an intensely *anxious-preoccupied attachment pattern* in which separation becomes psychologically threatening and loyalty becomes almost non-negotiable.



Elijah does not merely love Klaus; he repeatedly defines himself through his commitment to Klaus. Even after Klaus becomes violent, manipulative and destructive, Elijah continues returning to him. His loyalty therefore begins to resemble an emotional contract that cannot be revoked. Klaus may betray Elijah, dagger him (for those who didn't understand: Klaus is an attractive but controlling psychopath who drove a dagger through the hearts of his siblings which resulted in them being immobile and locked in a coffin until he decided to un-dagger them, which very well may be in centuries), manipulate him, imprison him or make catastrophically terrible decisions and Elijah will still, eventually, be standing there like the world's most elegant disappointed older brother.

And yet reducing this relationship to unhealthy attachment would be unfair. Elijah genuinely recognises something vulnerable in Klaus that others either cannot or will not see.

He understands that Klaus's brutality is not the whole of Klaus. He remembers the frightened brother underneath the monster. In psychological terms, Elijah demonstrates an extraordinary capacity for *mentalization*—the ability to perceive the internal psychological states, motives and emotional conflicts of another person rather than judging them solely by their observable behaviour. He repeatedly asks, implicitly or explicitly: *What happened to Klaus? What is he afraid of? What does he need? What made him this way?* His answer is almost always some variation of: *I will not abandon him*. That sentence, however, is both beautiful and tragic.

Klaus Mikaelson: Elijah's Favourite Psychological Project

There is perhaps no relationship in the entire Mikaelson family more psychologically complicated than Elijah and Klaus. Elijah becomes simultaneously Klaus's brother, protector, conscience, negotiator and rescuer.

He spends centuries trying to help Klaus control his worst impulses while also attempting to convince him that he is worthy of love. In doing so, Elijah develops what can be understood as a form of codependency: his emotional identity becomes strongly linked to Klaus's wellbeing, behaviour and survival.

The problem with *codependency* is that love can gradually become indistinguishable from responsibility. Elijah repeatedly behaves as though Klaus's choices are somehow his burden to manage. If Klaus becomes violent, Elijah tries to intervene. If Klaus is threatened, Elijah protects him. If Klaus becomes emotionally isolated, Elijah tries to reconnect him with the family. If Klaus destroys something, Elijah frequently finds himself attempting to rebuild it. At some point, one desperately wants to tell this thousand-year-old vampire: *sir, your brother is responsible for his own decisions.*

But Elijah cannot fully accept that principle because his love is built around protective responsibility. He has internalised the belief that abandoning Klaus would constitute a moral failure. This helps explain why Klaus's betrayal repeatedly hurts him so profoundly. Elijah is not merely losing trust in his brother; he is confronting a threat to the identity he has constructed around being Klaus's protector.

His forgiveness is therefore extraordinary but psychologically complicated. Klaus himself describes Elijah as a "master of forgiveness" and that description captures something fundamental about him. Elijah possesses a remarkable capacity for *reparative attachment* the tendency to preserve relationships despite injury by seeking restoration rather than permanent rupture. But forgiveness is not always the same thing as psychological health. Sometimes Elijah forgives because he genuinely believes people can change. At other times, he forgives because he cannot imagine himself abandoning his family. That distinction matters. Elijah's forgiveness is often an act of love, but it can also become a form of *self-erasure*.

He repeatedly places the family's survival above his own emotional wellbeing. He absorbs betrayal, grief and violence and then continues functioning. The result is a man who is extraordinarily resilient but who has very little practice asking the question: *what do I need?*

Always and Forever: The Family as Religion

The Mikaelson motto — *Always and Forever* — is more than a sentimental family slogan. Psychologically, it functions almost like a core schema: a deeply internalised belief that organises perception, decision-making and behaviour. For Elijah, family is not simply one important domain of life. Family is the organising principle around which his entire identity is constructed.

This explains why Elijah's loyalty extends beyond Klaus to Rebekah, Kol, Freya, Finn (his siblings), Hayley (his love interest) and eventually Hope (Klaus and Hayley's accidental daughter). His protective instincts repeatedly activate when family members are threatened, particularly those who are vulnerable or who cannot protect themselves. His relationship with Hope becomes especially significant because she represents something Elijah has spent centuries trying to preserve:

the possibility that the Mikaelson family can survive without repeating all of its historical violence. Hope is not merely Klaus's daughter; she becomes a symbol of continuity, redemption and possibility.

His relationship with Hayley similarly demonstrates that Elijah's loyalty is not restricted by conventional biological definitions of family. Hayley becomes family because she becomes important to Hope and Klaus, but also because Elijah genuinely comes to love and respect her. His protectiveness toward her is particularly revealing because it shows his tendency to transform affection into guardianship. Once Elijah loves someone, he rarely loves them casually. He commits. And Elijah does not seem to have discovered the concept of 'keeping things light.'

The Gentleman Has Entered the Chat

Now, we must address the obvious psychological phenomenon occurring whenever Elijah Mikaelson walks into a room.

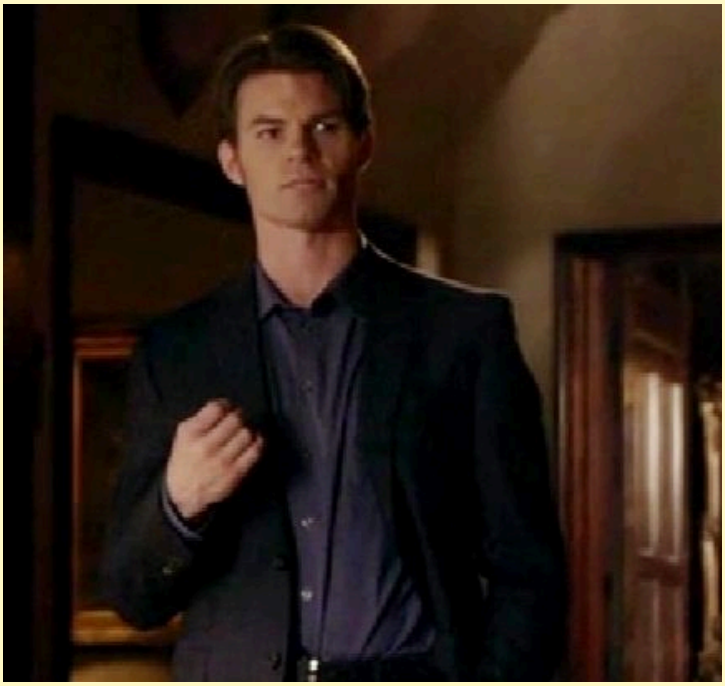
He is absurdly attractive.

This is not merely a fandom observation. The character is deliberately constructed around controlled masculinity: restrained body language, deliberate speech, formal clothing, emotional composure and a strong contrast between external calm and internal violence. The effect is psychologically powerful because he embodies the archetype of the controlled protector—someone who possesses enormous capacity for aggression but exercises restraint until a boundary is crossed.

And the suits. Good Lord, the suits. Elijah's clothing is part of his character language. His immaculate appearance communicates *self-regulation*, status, discipline and control. He does not look chaotic even when his life is. The visual message is essentially: I may have killed six people before breakfast, but I will be wearing a pocket square while doing it.

His manners similarly function as a *social boundary*. Elijah prefers civility, conversation and negotiation before violence. But when negotiation fails, the transition is chilling precisely because his aggression is controlled rather than impulsive. This gives his violence a distinctive psychological quality. He is rarely frightening because he appears out of control. He is frightening because he appears completely in control.

That is the difference between *impulsivity* and *instrumental aggression*. Elijah's violence is often purposeful. He can be brutal without becoming emotionally chaotic. The same man who can calmly discuss philosophy can, moments later, rip someone's heart out. The psychological dissonance is enormous—and, unfortunately for the rest of us, extremely compelling.



Good, Evil and the Extremely Inconvenient Middle

There is indeed a psychological concept relevant to Elijah's ability to embody apparently contradictory qualities: *moral complexity* and more specifically, *moral ambivalence*. He is neither psychologically nor morally reducible to 'good' or 'evil'.
Elijah possesses a strong moral framework, but his morality is context-dependent. He can be compassionate, generous and protective while simultaneously committing acts that would be horrifying by ordinary ethical standards. This is not necessarily evidence of hypocrisy. Rather, Elijah's moral system operates through competing values: protection of family, preservation of life, loyalty, justice, personal honour and individual compassion.

When these values conflict, family loyalty usually wins. This is where Elijah demonstrates something resembling *compartmentalization*.

Compartmentalization is a psychological *defence mechanism* through which conflicting thoughts, emotions or behaviours are separated into distinct mental compartments so that they can coexist without overwhelming the individual. Elijah can maintain an image of himself as a gentleman and protector while accepting the necessity of violence. He does not have to believe that he is a monster in order to commit monstrous acts; he can categorise those acts as necessary actions performed in defence of something morally meaningful.
And yet the fact that he experiences guilt, regret and compassion suggests that his conscience has not disappeared. Quite the opposite. His psychological conflict is partly produced because his conscience remains extremely active. Elijah is therefore not a character without morality. He is a character whose morality is constantly at war with his loyalty.

The Violence Beneath the Velvet

The most interesting thing about Elijah's violence is that it rarely defines his identity completely. Unlike characters who embrace violence as their *primary identity*, Elijah treats it as an instrument. This distinction is psychologically significant.
His self-concept is built around being civilised, protective, honourable and responsible. Violence becomes something he does rather than something he believes he is. That distinction allows him to preserve psychological continuity across centuries. He can participate in extreme violence without abandoning his *broader identity*.

However, this comes at a cost. The repeated exposure to violence, death and betrayal would plausibly contribute to *desensitization*, *hypervigilance* and emotional *compartmentalization*. Elijah has existed for approximately a millennium in environments where danger can appear at any moment. His extraordinary situational awareness and rapid threat assessment therefore make sense psychologically.

He is constantly reading the room. He knows who is lying (remember that post-ball scene with Elena?). He notices when someone is frightened. He anticipates betrayal. He rarely enters a situation without considering the possible consequences. This is essentially centuries of threat monitoring disguised as impeccable manners. And perhaps this is one reason Elijah seems so mature. He has simply had approximately one thousand years to become very, very tired of everyone's nonsense.

Love, According to Elijah Mikaelson

Elijah's attitude toward love is one of the most beautiful and tragic elements of his character. He does not appear to treat love casually. When Elijah speaks about love, it is usually associated with honour, loyalty and commitment. His belief that love should be honoured reveals an important psychological characteristic: *relational idealism*.

He does not seem to understand love as merely an emotion that exists between two people. He understands it as a commitment to another person's dignity, safety and wellbeing. That is why his relationships become so emotionally intense. When Elijah loves someone, he protects them, forgives them, sacrifices for them and repeatedly attempts to preserve the relationship even after it becomes painful.

This is why his love can sometimes become *self-sacrificial attachment*. He is willing to lose pieces of himself to preserve the people he loves. And there is something deeply romantic about that. There is also something deeply concerning about that. Psychologically speaking, please seek therapy, Elijah.

He once said that he's lived for a thousand years and rarely found love. And when he did, he has always honoured it. So he recognises that love is something that is important for him. And speaking of tragedies? Almost all his lovers suffered tragic fate by or because of Klaus—from Tatia, Katherine, Celeste, Gia, Hayley and others. So there is also an association of guilt with love.

Rebekah once said that loving any of them is essentially a death sentence. And Elijah, mirroring those words, has always maintained an almost... cautious approach towards love.

Hayley and Hope

Elijah's relationship with Hayley is particularly important because it allows his protective identity to evolve. His feelings for her are not simply an extension of his relationship with Klaus. He recognises Hayley as an independent individual with her own strength, intelligence and agency.

With Hope, however, the emotional stakes become even greater. Hope represents the future of the Mikaelson family and Elijah becomes deeply invested in protecting her. His relationship with her activates his *caregiving* system, a psychological motivational system associated with protecting vulnerable individuals and promoting their survival.

But Hope also represents redemption. Elijah's entire life has been about preserving a family that repeatedly destroys itself. Hope provides evidence that something new might emerge from that history. She is not simply another Mikaelson. She is the possibility that the Mikaelsons can become something other than what they have always been.

That makes Elijah's eventual decisions concerning Hope and Klaus devastating because they force him into the ultimate conflict between two of his strongest psychological commitments: protecting the future and remaining loyal to the past.

The Wisdom of a Man Who Has Seen Everything

Elijah's wisdom is not simply intelligence. It is experiential intelligence—knowledge developed through centuries of observation, consequence and repeated exposure to human behaviour.

He understands patterns. He understands revenge. He understands fear. He understands how power changes people. Most importantly, he understands that people are rarely psychologically simple.

His wit reflects this intelligence. Elijah's humour is usually understated rather than flamboyant. He does not need to dominate a room verbally because his confidence is already established. His humour often emerges through dry observations, subtle sarcasm and the sheer absurdity of the situations in which he finds himself.

This restraint is consistent with his broader *self-monitoring*. He rarely reveals everything he is thinking. His emotional expression is measured, which creates an aura of mystery around him. And yes, this is another reason the fandom has collectively lost its mind.

The Psychology of Self-Control

If there is one psychological concept that defines Elijah more than almost anything else, it is *inhibitory control*. He possesses an extraordinary ability to suppress immediate impulses in favour of longer-term goals. He can tolerate provocation, postpone revenge, negotiate under pressure and remain composed during emotionally devastating circumstances.

But *self-control* is not synonymous with emotional absence.

Elijah feels intensely. He simply regulates intensely. This distinction matters because Elijah is often mistaken for emotionally cold. In reality, he is emotionally contained. The difference is enormous. *Emotional suppression* involves pushing feelings away; *emotional regulation* involves managing the expression and intensity of those feelings so that behaviour remains aligned with one's goals. Elijah's entire personality is essentially an exercise in *emotional regulation*...
Until someone threatens his family.

The Tragedy of the Martyr

Perhaps the darkest psychological dimension of Elijah's character is his tendency toward martyrdom. He repeatedly sacrifices his own happiness, freedom and emotional wellbeing for the sake of his family.
Martyr behaviour can emerge when an individual derives identity and meaning from self-sacrifice. Elijah frequently appears to experience precisely this dynamic. Being the protector gives his existence purpose. If everyone else is safe, then his suffering becomes acceptable. The problem is that when identity becomes dependent on protecting others, *self-preservation* can begin to feel selfish.
This helps explain why Elijah can tolerate extraordinary suffering. He does not necessarily believe that his own happiness deserves the same protection he gives everyone else. And that is perhaps the saddest thing about him. The man who spends centuries telling everyone else that they deserve another chance rarely gives himself one.

Why "Always and Forever" Means So Much

'Always and Forever' is ultimately Elijah's psychological thesis. It is his promise, his identity, his *attachment system*, his *moral code* and occasionally, his prison.
The phrase represents *secure attachment* as an ideal even though the Mikaelsons repeatedly fail to achieve *secure attachment* in practice. Elijah wants a family in which separation does not mean abandonment and conflict does not mean permanent rejection. He keeps returning because he wants to prove that love can survive betrayal.
In this sense, Elijah is engaged in a lifelong attempt at *attachment repair*. He is trying to create the family security he did not fully experience in childhood. The tragedy is that he repeatedly confuses preserving the family with preserving the family exactly as it is. Sometimes the people he loves need to change. Sometimes they need boundaries. Sometimes they need distance. And sometimes, heartbreakingly, loving someone means accepting that you cannot save them.
Elijah spends much of his existence resisting that truth.

So, Is Elijah Mikaelson a Good Man?

No.
Also yes.
And that is precisely the point. Elijah is not a moral saint. He is a deeply traumatised immortal who has committed horrific acts. He is capable of murder, manipulation, coercion and vengeance. He has blood on his hands that no amount of tailoring can hide. But he is also compassionate, loyal, protective, introspective, forgiving and deeply committed to the people he loves. His character cannot be reduced to either side.

Elijah represents *moral complexity*: the coexistence of contradictory *moral impulses* within one individual. He demonstrates that people can possess genuine compassion and still commit terrible acts, just as someone capable of violence can also possess profound tenderness. The important question is not whether Elijah is good or evil. The more interesting question is what does he do with the conflict between the two? And the answer is: he carries it. For centuries. "Always and forever" indeed.

The Man Beneath the Monster

Ultimately, Elijah Mikaelson is a study in *identity, attachment, trauma, loyalty, self-sacrifice, emotional regulation, moral conflict* and the human—or, in his case, supernatural—desire to belong.

He is the brother who cannot abandon. The protector who cannot rest. The gentleman who can become a monster. The monster who still believes compassion is sacred. The man who forgives almost everyone except, perhaps, himself.

His relationship with Klaus demonstrates the extraordinary power and danger of *attachment*. His devotion to his family demonstrates the psychological consequences of *parentification* and *codependency*. His composure reflects exceptional *emotional regulation* and *inhibitory control*. His violence illustrates *moral compartmentalization* and *instrumental aggression*. His compassion reflects *empathy* and *prosociality*. His willingness to sacrifice himself reveals the darker side of *self-sacrificial identity*.

And his endless commitment to "Always and Forever" reflects both the beauty and burden of an individual whose deepest psychological need is to ensure that the people he loves are never abandoned.

And then, of course, there is the fact that he can say things like, "Your compassion is a gift, Elena. Carry it with you always," while looking like *that*. Which frankly feels psychologically unfair.

Perhaps Elijah's greatest tragedy is that he spends so much of his life trying to become the person his family needs that he gradually loses sight of the person he himself might have wanted to be. He carries everyone else's fear so that they can remain fearless. He absorbs their chaos so that they can experience stability. He forgives because someone has to. He protects because someone has to. He stays because *someone* has to.

And in the End, He Kept His Promise

Perhaps the most important thing to understand about Elijah is that, for all his wisdom, restraint and centuries of experience, there was one promise from which he never learned to walk away: Always and Forever. It was not merely a childhood vow shared between siblings; it became the foundation of his identity, the psychological contract around which he built his entire existence.

Elijah spent a thousand years protecting Klaus, forgiving Klaus, guiding Klaus, believing in Klaus and perhaps most importantly,

refusing to abandon him. He could recognise Klaus's darkness without believing that the darkness was all he was. He could condemn his brother's actions and still love the person underneath them. He could spend centuries trying to save Klaus from himself, even when Klaus repeatedly made that task almost comically impossible. And when the end finally came, Elijah was faced with the one thing he had spent his entire life trying to prevent: a world in which Klaus would have to face eternity without his brother beside him.

So Elijah made the choice that, psychologically, was both devastating and completely consistent. He chose Klaus. He chose to die with him. There is something almost unbearably poignant about the fact that Elijah, who had spent centuries believing his purpose was to protect Klaus, ultimately could not conceive of protection as surviving him. His final act was not another attempt to control Klaus's fate, redeem him or persuade him to become someone else. It was simply companionship. For once, Elijah did not try to save his brother from death. He decided that Klaus would not have to meet it alone. The protector finally stopped protecting; the mediator stopped negotiating; the brother stopped trying to repair what could no longer be repaired. He simply *stayed*.

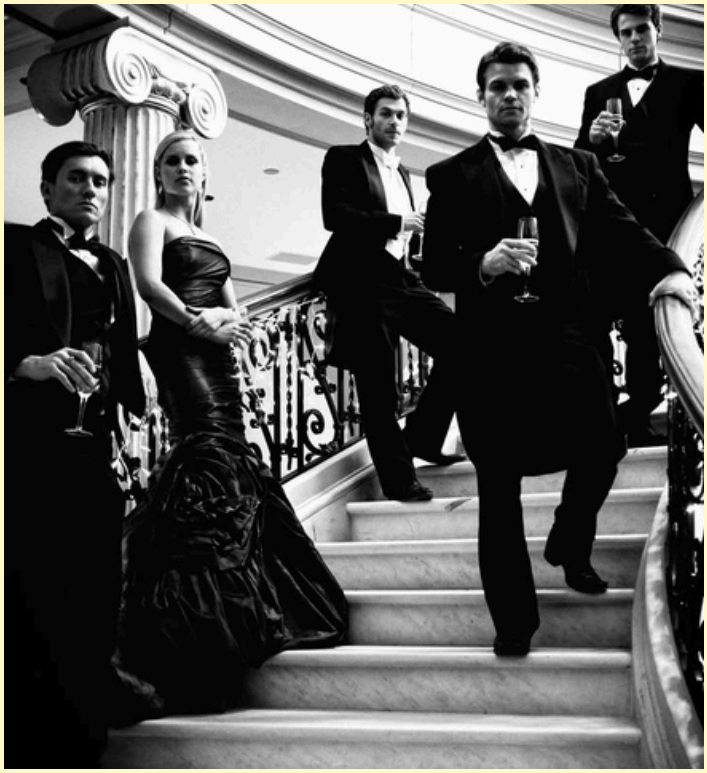
And that, perhaps, is the most complete expression of Elijah's psychology. *Attachment* had been his greatest strength and his greatest vulnerability; *self-sacrifice* had been his defining pattern; loyalty had repeatedly overridden his instinct for *self-preservation*; and "Always and Forever" had been both his guiding principle and his prison. In the end, all of those threads converged in one final decision. Elijah could have lived. He could have walked away. He could have imagined a future that did not revolve around protecting his family. Instead, he looked at the brother he had spent a millennium trying to save and decided that if Klaus's story was ending, then his own would end beside it.

And perhaps that is why their final scene hurts so much. Elijah does not die because he has failed to love Klaus. He dies because he has loved him exactly as he promised he would. A thousand years earlier, two brothers made a vow that sounded almost impossibly simple: Always and Forever. After everything—betrayals, violence, heartbreak, separation, forgiveness, loss and the countless times they nearly destroyed one another—they kept it.

Klaus once called Elijah a master of forgiveness. Perhaps he was. But Elijah's greatest gift was not forgiveness. It was devotion: the extraordinary, sometimes beautiful and sometimes deeply destructive ability to remain when everyone else had left. He spent his life believing that family was something you protected even when it hurt, that love was something you honoured even when it cost you and that the people you called your own should never have to face the darkness alone.

And so, when the darkness finally came for Klaus, Elijah went with him. No suit could save him. No centuries of wisdom could negotiate with death. No plan could repair this one. There was only his brother. And, after a thousand years, there was only one promise left to keep.

Always and forever.



**A note to the Klaus fans— Before the Klaus Mikaelson fan club sends us a strongly worded letter: we love Klaus too. This article may have occasionally, very gently, pointed out his psychological instability, questionable life choices and tendency to turn family disagreements into international incidents, but please understand that this is said with affection. Klaus is, after all, complicated, tragic, hilarious and ridiculously compelling. So, Klaus fans, we come in peace. We are merely analysing the man—not cancelling him. Please put the daggers down.*

**A note on the Klaus problem—You may have noticed that Klaus keeps turning up in an analysis that is supposedly about Elijah. This is not an editorial failure; it is, unfortunately, Elijah Mikaelson's entire psychological problem. Elijah is absolutely his own person, with his own values, desires, relationships and moral compass, but Klaus gets a rather disproportionate amount of screen time in his emotional biography. For a thousand years, Elijah has protected him, guided him, forgiven him, fought for him, worried about him and occasionally looked at him with the exhausted expression of a man reconsidering every life choice he has ever made. So Klaus has to get a say. It is both deeply humorous and profoundly tragic: Elijah's life is his own, yet so much of it has been organised around the person he refuses to abandon. And, as we eventually discover, even death does not quite manage to separate them.*

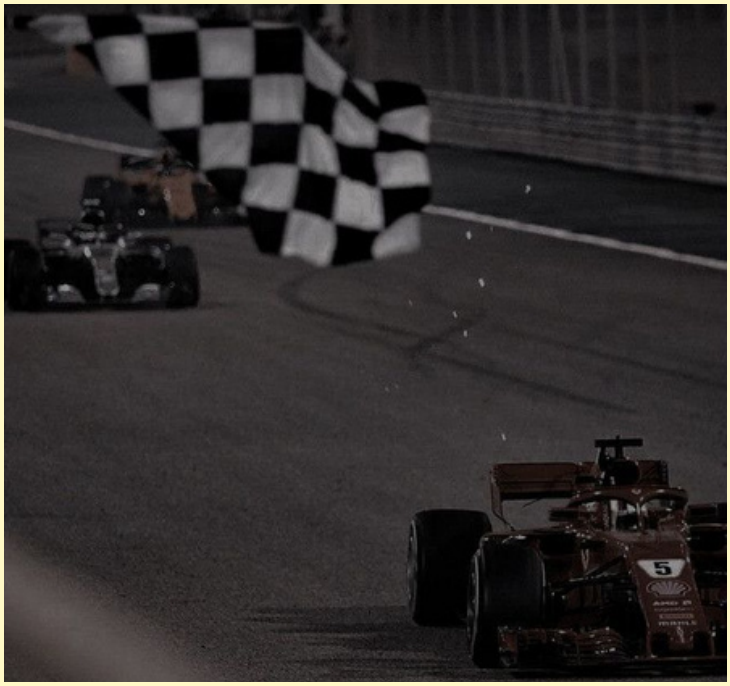
INTO THE MIND OF A *Formula 1 Driver*

By Maira K.B Wala

The Formula One World Championship began in 1950, attracting the world's best racing teams and drivers to compete in the most prestigious races. The first official World Championship race was held at Silverstone, England, May of 1950.

Presently, motorsport represents one of the world's most popular and globally followed sports. The FIA Formula 1 World Championship captivates millions of viewers worldwide through their unique blend of cutting edge technology, extreme physical demands and high stakes competition. The sport's appeal extends beyond mere entertainment, as these elite racing series showcase human performance at the absolute limits of speed, precision and decision-making under extreme pressure. That being said, popular media often mythologizes Formula 1 drivers as fearless and adrenaline-fueled gladiators who operate on an almost transcendental level. But from the psychological perspective, the psyche of a formula one driver is multi-dimensional and deeper than just an intrinsic urge to put the pedal to the metal.

A big determinant in the structure of a driver's beliefs, motivations and mental capacity is their environment. Past the variables that are inevitable from team to team, season to season and driver to driver, few constants come to light. For instance, team politics, rising expectations from



audiences to perform, extensive physical training and simulator work behind the scenes, travelling 24 times a year, sticking to a strict schedule and also managing media responsibilities.

The innate risk factor in the sport is yet another constant that sets the limits of how far a driver can push themselves. Furthermore, Cockpits in Formula 1 are known for their high levels of complexity due to the need to optimize vehicle performance—the cars' capabilities and the nature of motorsport subject the drivers to an additional range of stressors. In this context, being able to regulate mental states under pressure, developing suitable coping mechanisms optimizing competitive performance while simultaneously maintaining the cognitive vigilance necessary to prevent potentially fatal errors become

indispensable skills. Elite performers demonstrate distinct psychological characteristics, with successful athletes exhibiting less depressed, less sensitive, yet more confident, more anxious and aggressive profiles compared to less successful counterparts. Research also indicates that successful drivers demonstrate superior abilities in mental-imaging, stress control, attention and goal setting.

Importantly, these psychological skills are more attributable to learning over years of experience in the right environment than simply 'natural ability' or 'innate talent' of the drivers. And even then, research shows that only a few of these skills show significant development with more experience, underscoring the need for intervention of systematic psychological skills training.

Interestingly, the psychological stimuli that the drivers are exposed to has also been found to produce very physically visible responses. For instance, during a race, a driver's heart rate has been shown to reach anywhere from 140 to 180 beats per minute. Although race car driving is physically strenuous, the high heart rate is not necessarily just a physiological response to the physical demand of driving. In 2011, Matsumura and colleagues found that drivers' heart rate values during races (168.8 beats per minute) were significantly higher than their heart rate values during solo driving (140.9 beats/min), leading to the conclusion that competition heightens heart rate in drivers. The reverse is also true, wherein physical stimuli affects psychological capabilities. During a race, drivers' core temperature can rise to 40–41°C (even 50 C in some cases) , and they can lose 5–10% of their body weight due to dehydration. These high temperatures have been shown to decrease reaction time and potentially performance. Ayrton Senna would run in the heat of Brazil a distance of 8 kilometers, 16 kilometers, and 24 kilometers on successive days to acclimatize himself to these brutal conditions. Moreover, high heat is not the only physical stressor in Formula 1. Drivers must manage very powerful G-forces from all directions (turning left, right, accelerating,braking) with the muscles of their neck. During a turn, a driver can experience lateral g-forces up to 5G. The average head and helmet weighs around 4kg, meaning that during a 5G turn, the muscles of the neck would have to support up to 20kg of force at each high G turn for the duration of the grand prix (~ 2 hrs).

Drivers' oxygen uptake while racing has been shown to be more than 75% of their peak oxygen consumption and 9– 13 times their resting metabolic rates. All of these stressors, plus the uncomfortable seating position drivers adopt, put a high degree of stress on the physical as well as mental systems of drivers. Formula One is regarded as one of the most dangerous sports in the world [Fifty-four injuries and twenty deaths occurred during races, qualifying, and practice sessions from 1950 to 1996]. When you're driving at over 350 km/h , a single second of lost focus can mean the difference between winning a race and a dangerous crash. Because the stakes are so high, motorsport naturally weeds people out, favoring drivers who can hold absolute concentration under pressure. The parallel between motorsport and other risk sports is

meaningful as both involve unpredictable and dangerous sporting environments where even the smallest of mistakes can have extreme consequences.

Research with elite volleyball players revealed that elite performers recorded higher scores across all mental skill dimensions, demonstrating that psychological skills play increasingly important roles in reaching peak performance levels as competitive demands intensify.

The concentration superiority demonstrated by F1 drivers also parallels psychological demands across other life-critical occupations. Military pilots, for instance, operating in single-seat multirole fighter aircraft are exposed to a demanding cognitive work environment, implying intense physical and psychological stress and fatigue. Research consistently indicates that impaired attention, slower reaction time, reduced vigilance and problem-solving directly impact safety across aviation contexts, suggesting that concentration advantages seen in F1 drivers are necessary adaptations that can be generalised to other high-stakes domains as well where split-second decisions determine both performance and safety consequences.

Formula one therefore provides a compelling lens through which we can understand the limits of human performance under extreme conditions. And most perhaps more importantly, the psychological profile of an elite driver should not be understood as the product of fearlessness or innate talent alone. Years of experience, environmental demands, deliberate training and psychological skills development all contribute to the ability to perform consistently under pressure. The same principles extend beyond Formula 1 to occupations such as military aviation, MotoGP, Endurance racing etc.

Ultimately, Formula One illustrates a broader principle of human psychology: at the limits of performance, success depends not on the absence of stress or risk, but on the capacity to regulate, adapt and perform effectively within them.

THE PSYCHOLOGY OF *Cults*

When belonging becomes a trap

By Shambhavi Parmar

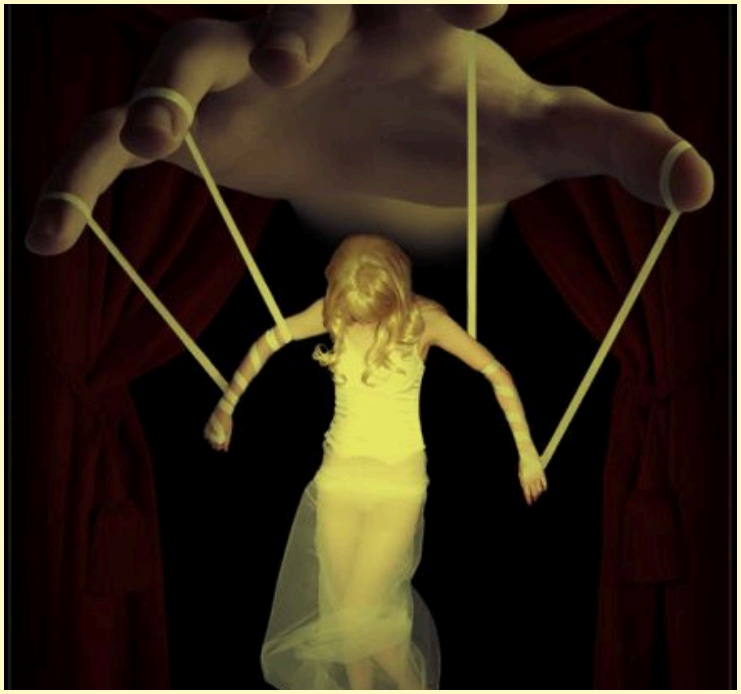
"The most dangerous prisons are not always built with walls. Sometimes, they are built with words."

Imagine going through the worst phase of your life and meeting a group of people that make you feel seen in months. They listen to your problems, encourage your talents and tell you that you have finally found people who truly understand you. They invite you to dinners, praise your habits. It feels safe, like a friendship even.

Now imagine, months later, those same people tell you to stop talking to your family because they "don't understand you." They ask you to trust only one leader. They convince you that leaving would destroy your future, hopes and aspirations.

The frightening part is that these two situations can be part of the same story.

When we hear the word cult, we often picture mysterious rituals, isolated compounds, or people who blindly follow a leader or consider them a god. It feels like something that belongs in documentaries rather than in our real lives. Psychology reveals a far more scary truth: cult members are rarely foolish or unintelligent. Many are students, parents, artists and people who were simply searching for belonging, hope or purpose to live by. The psychology of cults is not about strange people making strange choices. It is about understanding how regular human needs until loyalty is replaced with their own freedom.



What Is a Cult?

There is no single legal definition of a **cult**, but psychologists generally describe it as *a group that exercises excessive control over its members through emotional, psychological or social manipulation*. Healthy communities encourage questioning of their belief system, support personal interest or choices and exercise communication with our individuals. Cults often do the opposite. They discourage questions and impose their choices on you as if they were your own, they make following the leader more prevalent than our own wishes. The danger is not unusual beliefs alone. Many harmless groups have uncommon beliefs. The real warning sign is when a group controls how people think, feel or make decisions.

Why Do Ordinary People Join?

One of the biggest myths about cults is that

only ‘weak-minded’ people join them or are somehow easily lured into the rat trap that offers everything you want until it closes in leaving you stranded. Research does not support this idea.

Psychologist Abraham Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs explains that humans naturally seek love, belonging, and purpose after their basic needs are met. During emotionally difficult periods, such as loneliness, grief, family conflict or uncertainty about the future, these needs become even stronger. Cults often appear during exactly these vulnerable moments.

They rarely introduce themselves as dangerous organizations. Instead, they present themselves as supportive communities offering friendship, personal growth, spirituality or a meaningful mission, basically something that can pull you out of your current mental state and help you get back on your feet.

People usually join because they are attracted to *hope*, not control. There are quite a few methods and stages of reeling a person into a cult, leaving off their family, friends or even their principles. **Love Bombing** is the illusion of unconditional love and acceptance. It is one of the most common recruitment techniques. New members receive overwhelming kindness. They are praised, hugged, invited to gatherings and made to feel valued almost immediately. At first, the affection feels genuine. The psychological effect is powerful because our brains naturally respond positively to acceptance and social approval. Feeling appreciated releases positive emotions that strengthen trust and attachment. However, in many **cults** this affection gradually becomes conditional. Approval depends on obedience. Questioning anything begins to threaten acceptance. They train your mind suchthat you'll be loved only if you cut off your family, perform a specific ritual or surrender your assets (materialistic or physical). The Power of Charismatic Leaders

Nearly every famous cult has been built around a charismatic leader. Sociologist Max Weber described charismatic authority as power that comes from followers believing someone possesses extraordinary qualities rather than official qualifications.These leaders often claim to have special spiritual knowledge, unique solutions to society's problems or an important destiny that others cannot understand.

Interestingly, most charismatic leaders do not demand complete obedience on the first day. They try to earn the trust of the followers. Once emotional dependence develops, control becomes much easier.

The Foot-in-the-Door Effect

Imagine someone asks you to attend one free meeting. That feels harmless. Next, they invite you to another. Later, they ask you to volunteer. Then they encourage donations. Eventually, they expect most of your time and loyalty solely for them. Psychologists call this the foot-in-the-door effect.

When people agree to small requests first, they become more likely to accept much larger requests later. Each step seems only slightly bigger than the previous one, making dramatic change almost invisible while it happens. It feels like adding a single particle of salt to water, it's unnoticeable until it's too much. Looking back, outsiders may see a huge transformation. Living through it, members often experience only small changes that alter the course of their lives.

When the Group Becomes Your Identity

Psychologists Henri Tajfel and John Turner developed Social Identity Theory, explaining that people build part of their identity through the groups they are associated with or belong to. We naturally describe ourselves through our communities—as a student or a political member or fan of a particular sport. These identities create a sense of belongingness. Cults push this process much further.

Instead of simply belonging to a group, members begin believing that the group defines their *entire* worth.

The world becomes divided into "us" and "them". The new members are told to choose between the world or the community (**cult**). *Insiders* become the closest ones. *Outsiders* become dangerous, jealous or misunderstood. This makes leaving incredibly painful because members fear losing not only friends but also their entire identity.

Brainwashing Is a Slow Process

The word **brainwashing** often sounds like instant mind control shown in movies. But rather than one dramatic moment, it is usually a gradual process of influence. Psychologist *Robert Jay Lifton*, who studied thought reform, identified several common techniques used by controlling groups—

Controlling Information: Members are discouraged from reading outside books, watching critical news or speaking with former members. When people hear only one version of reality repeatedly, questioning becomes much harder. The control extends to the tiniest pieces of information, including when a member is seeking help. They are pulled back down if they ever seek help.

Confession: Followers may be encouraged to confess personal mistakes or weaknesses. These confessions create vulnerability and increase emotional dependence on the group. Sometimes even give the group enough to emotionally blackmail the person into staying.

Single Truth: The leader's words become unquestionable. Disagreement is treated as evidence that the member

who questioned is themselves flawed rather than the leader themselves.

Endless Purity: Members are constantly told they must become better, purer or more loyal. This creates guilt that keeps them working harder for approval. As the members already are craving approval, they do whatever it takes to win even a tiny ounce of it.

The Psychology of Obedience

One of psychology's most famous experiments was conducted by *Stanley Milgram*. Participants believed they were giving painful electric shocks to another person because an authority instructed them to continue. Many obeyed even when they appeared deeply uncomfortable. The study suggested something unsettling: *ordinary people often obey authority more than they expect*. Inside **cults**, leaders become powerful authority figures. When obedience becomes connected with morality, followers may perform actions they would have rejected before joining.

The Pressure to Conform

Psychologist *Solomon Asch* demonstrated that people sometimes give obviously incorrect answers simply because everyone else in the group agrees. This is called **conformity**. Inside **cults**, **conformity** becomes even stronger because members spend most of their time surrounded by people who repeat the same beliefs.

Eventually, doubting yourself feels easier than doubting everyone around you.

Why Leaving Feels Impossible

Many outsiders ask, “Why didn't they just leave?”

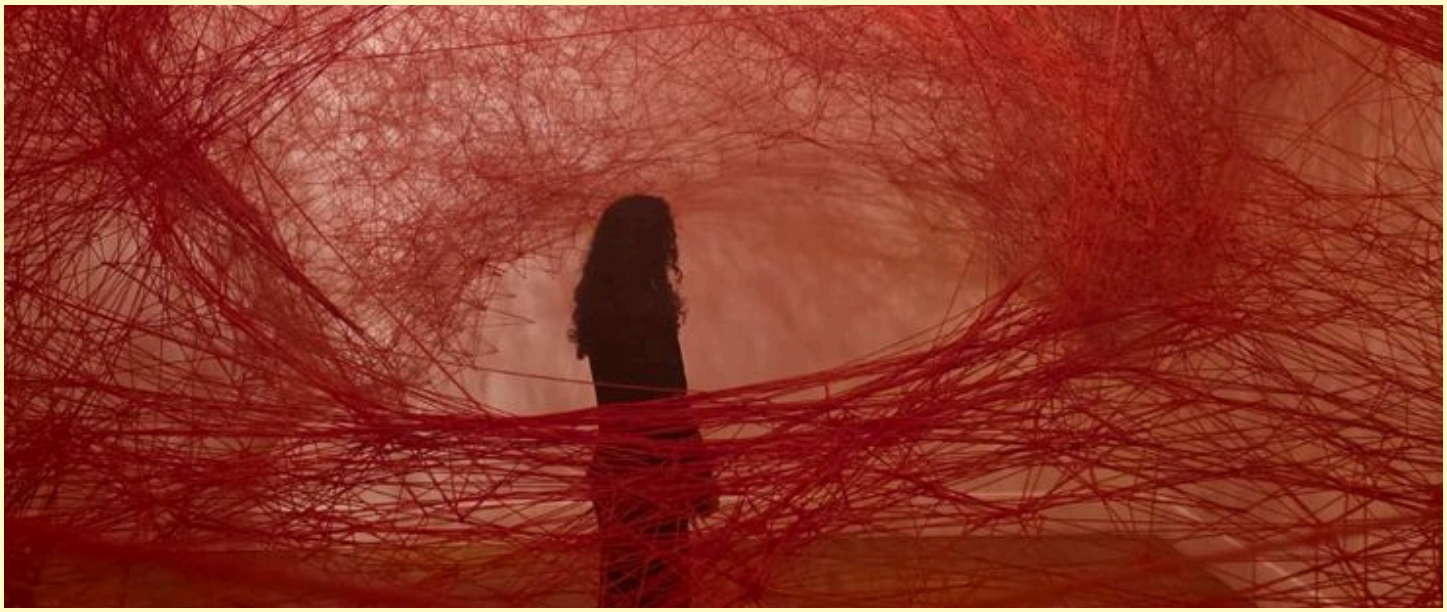
The actual answer is surprisingly complex. Leaving may mean losing: family, friends, financial support and an entire sense of identity. Some groups convince members that terrible things will happen if they leave. Others publicly shame former members.

Another important concept is **cognitive dissonance**, introduced by psychologist *Leon Festinger*. When people sacrifice years of their lives, money, relationships and identity for a group, admitting it was harmful creates *painful mental conflict*. Instead of accepting that pain, many convince themselves they made the right choice.

Ironically, the greater the sacrifice, the harder leaving can become.

Can Social Media Create Cult-Like Behavior?

Today's psychologists have begun asking whether some online communities can develop cult-like dynamics. Most online groups are completely harmless. However, certain warning signs resemble classic psychological patterns: unquestionable loyalty to influencers, attacking critics, claiming access to “secret truths”, discouraging independent thinking and



reating an “us versus them” mindset.
Social media algorithms can strengthen these patterns by repeatedly showing similar content, creating *echo chambers* where one viewpoint prevails. Although this is not the same as a traditional **cult**, it demonstrates how psychological influence has adapted to the digital age.

Conclusion

Perhaps the most important lesson the psychology of cults teaches us is not to be afraid of belonging, but to be careful about what we *surrender* in order to belong.

We all need people. We need communities, friendships, guidance and something larger than ourselves to believe in. There is nothing weak about wanting to be understood. In fact, the desire for connection is one of the most deeply human things about us. The danger begins when belonging comes at the price of individuality.
So how do we protect ourselves?
Keep the right to question. A healthy community will not punish you for asking “why?” If a belief cannot survive a question, it is worth questioning.
Maintain relationships outside the group. Keep your family, old friends, interests and connections alive. A community should add to your world, not replace it.
Make decisions slowly when emotions are complex. Be especially cautious when someone pressures you to make immediate commitments involving money, relationships, isolation or major life choices. Give yourself time. Talk to someone outside the situation.
Protect your independent sources of information. Read opposing perspectives. Speak to people who disagree with you. Seek advice from people who have nothing to gain from your decision. Independence becomes much harder to manipulate when your reality is not controlled by a single voice.
And perhaps most importantly, remember that changing your mind is not weakness. Walking away from something you once believed in does not mean you were foolish for believing it. It means you are capable of learning.

After all, the strongest prison may be built with words—but the first step out of it can also be a word:“Why?”

A STUDY IN NEURODIVERGENCE

Rewiring Creativity

By Rishika Singhi

"The human mind is not a single standard mechanism, but an ever-shifting architecture of possibilities."

Ever had about thirty tabs open in your browser, a random song playing on loop in the back of your mind and suddenly—out of nowhere—you connect two completely unrelated ideas and solve a problem you've been stuck on for days? Sounds like a chaotic afternoon, right? Well, for millions of neurodivergent people, that isn't chaos—it's just the way it flows.

For decades, traditional psychology treated conditions like ADHD (Attention-Deficit Hyperactivity Disorder), Autism and Dyslexia almost exclusively as "deficits"—disorders to be corrected or quieted down so people could fit neatly into standard boxes. But modern cognitive neuroscience tells a completely different story. These neurological variations aren't broken wires. They're just alternative operating systems, fundamentally altering how the brain filters, processes, and paints reality.

ADHD: Uninhibited Ideation and the Hyperfocus Paradox

If a neurotypical brain acts like a strict security guard at a club—checking IDs and letting thoughts in one by one—the ADHD brain leaves the VIP doors wide open and lets everyone in at once. At a neurobiological level, Attention Deficit Hyperactivity Disorder is driven by reduced cognitive inhibition paired with unique dopamine pathway dynamics. While this

an make mundane, repetitive tasks feel as agonizing as watching paint dry, it creates the ultimate playground for divergent thinking—the ability to generate dozens of wildly original ideas from a single prompt.

An ADHD mind doesn't do linear thinking. A concept in physics triggers a memory of a jazz rhythm, which instantly links to a visual color scheme. Because the brain's filter doesn't discard 'irrelevant' peripheral information right away, it holds disparate concepts in working memory simultaneously, allowing creators to make radical, unexpected connections.

And then, of course, there's distractibility's famous sibling: hyperfocus. When an ADHD brain stumbles upon a topic it actually cares about, dopamine floods the system. The rest of the world fades out, time completely disappears and the person enters an intense, almost supernatural flow state—working for

ten hours straight until a conceptual spark becomes a finished masterpiece. Oscar-winning filmmaker Steven Spielberg and iconic director Tim Burton have both spoken about how their neurodivergent traits and intense visual hyperfocus helped shape their legendary, otherworldly cinematic universes!

Autism: Pattern Thinking and Visual Synthesis

While ADHD thrives on rapid expansion and leaping between ideas, autism often excels in breathtaking structural depth, precision, and systemic clarity.

Moving past outdated stereotypes, cognitive research highlights a phenomenon called Enhanced Perceptual Functioning (EPF) in autistic individuals. Essentially, the visual and sensory regions of the brain operate at a higher resolution, picking up micro-details, structural anomalies and subtle patterns that typical processing completely glosses over.

Many autistic creators don't think in words at all—they think in high-definition images. Instead of pondering abstract concepts linguistically, they construct detailed 3D mental models in their mind's eye. Every angle, weight and component can be rotated, inspected and stress-tested internally before a single sketch is drawn or line of code is written. This visual orientation goes hand-in-hand with an innate drive to systemize—to uncover underlying rules, mathematical symmetries and visual logic across complex structures. Whether analyzing musical compositions, architectural frameworks, or software architectures, this deep perceptual focus allows autistic creators to discover elegant order where others see only noise.

Dyslexia: *"Big-Picture Vision"*

Long categorized simply as a reading difficulty, dyslexia is actually a specialized cognitive trade-off oriented toward multi-dimensional spatial reasoning. Because the dyslexic brain processes written text non-linearly, it compensates by relying heavily on the brain's visuospatial sketchpad—the neural network responsible for depth perception, 3D mapping and spatial orientation.

Dyslexic thinkers consistently outshine their peers when it comes to mental rotation and spatial manipulation. They don't just view an object or a concept from a flat, two-dimensional angle; they intuitively rotate it in physical space, seeing how all its moving parts fit together.

While traditional learning often forces a step-by-step, inside-out approach to problem-solving, dyslexic cognition works from the outside in. It grasps complex, interconnected systems as a single, holistic ecosystem. In fields like architecture, industrial design, engineering and storytelling, this ability to zoom out and synthesize massive amounts of spatial information makes dyslexic thinkers remarkably inventive. They spot overarching narratives, structural flaws and big-picture possibilities long before linear analysis catches up.

Beyond the Neurotypical Mind

When you look across ADHD, Autism and Dyslexia, one thing becomes crystal clear: human innovation has never come from a standardized, factory-model brain. From the uninhibited divergent leaps of ADHD and the meticulous structural clarity of Autism to the holistic 3D vision of Dyslexia, neurodivergence reshapes the very canvas of human thought. Creativity doesn't happen in spite of these cognitive differences—it happens precisely because of them.

After all, if everyone processed the world the exact same way, imagine how boring the gallery would be!

WHY ALMOST-HUMAN THINGS FEEL SO *Unsettling*

By Nairity Rajput

"In a horror movie, why is it always a doll? Seriously. Think of Annabelle: porcelain skin, wide eyes, a tiny smile, perfectly still. In theory, there is nothing particularly threatening about her. She cannot chase you, punch you or even walk unless the laws of physics have collectively resigned. And yet, place that same doll alone in a dark room, turn its head slightly towards you and suddenly everyone develops a very strong interest in leaving the room. But perhaps the creepiest part is that the doll does not even have to move.

There is something deeply unsettling about objects that look almost human. A cartoon character is usually harmless precisely because it is obviously fictional. A monster can be terrifying, but at least your brain knows what category to put it in: monster. A completely mechanical robot may look strange, but its metal body tells you immediately that it is not a person.

The trouble begins when something gets very close to human without quite getting there. The skin looks real. The eyes look real. The smile is almost right. The movements are almost natural. And yet something inside you quietly whispers:Nope. Something is wrong here. This strange psychological phenomenon is known as the uncanny valley.

The idea was proposed by Japanese roboticist Masahiro Mori in 1970. Mori suggested that as an artificial object becomes increasingly human-like, our emotional response generally becomes more positive—until the object gets extremely close to resembling a real person. At that point, instead of becoming even more comfortable our response may suddenly plunge into discomfort or eeriness.

Imagine a spectrum. On one end is a cartoon character: obviously artificial, but familiar and friendly. Move along the spectrum and you encounter increasingly realistic robots, prosthetics, digital humans and eventually something almost indistinguishable from a real person. Then comes the valley. The strange thing is that the object is not necessarily more frightening because it looks more human. In fact, the problem may be that it looks human enough to activate all the expectations we normally have about human beings—but not human enough to satisfy them.

Modern research has found that the simple

claim ‘the more human something looks, the creepier it becomes near the end’ does not consistently hold across experiments. A major review found relatively little support for the classic uncanny-valley curve by itself. However, there was considerably stronger evidence for a related explanation: perceptual mismatch, where different aspects of an artificial character suggest conflicting levels of realism. In other words, perhaps the valley is not simply about being too human. Perhaps it is about being human in the *wrong* way. To understand why this happens, we first need to understand how important faces are to us. The human brain is remarkably specialised for processing faces. We effortlessly extract information about identity, emotion, age and attention from a face, often without consciously analysing any of it. Research on face perception has identified a distributed network of face-selective brain regions involved in recognising and interpreting faces. This means that when you see something resembling a human face, your brain does not simply think: *interesting arrangement of pixels*.

It starts making *predictions*. The eyes should move naturally. The face should respond to what is happening. Movements should have a recognisably human rhythm. Expressions should change in ways that make social sense. Most of the time, these processes happen so automatically that we never notice them. Until something breaks the pattern.

Imagine a digital human with incredibly realistic skin, hair and facial proportions. Everything looks perfect—until it smiles. The mouth moves beautifully, but the eyes remain strangely still. Or the voice sounds completely human while the face looks artificial. Or the head moves naturally,

but the expression seems frozen. Each individual detail might seem minor. Together, they produce something much more powerful. This is where **perceptual mismatch** becomes especially important. Research reviewed by *Kätsyri* and colleagues found evidence that uncanny responses can arise when different features of an artificial character have inconsistent levels of realism—for example, when highly realistic eyes are paired with a less realistic face, or when unusual features are placed on an otherwise realistic face. Similar effects have also been observed when visual appearance and voice do not match.

Our perception normally works by combining multiple signals. When those signals agree, the result feels coherent. When they conflict, the result can feel eerie.

This may explain why some computer-generated people look completely normal

from a distance but become unsettling when you stare at them. You begin noticing tiny inconsistencies.

Eyes and gaze are central to human social interaction. They help us determine where another person is looking, what they are attending to and to some extent, what they might be feeling or intending. Research reviews describe the eye region as particularly important for identity, emotion and social communication. That makes the eyes unusually powerful in an almost-human face.

A mannequin can have perfect hair, realistic skin and carefully sculpted lips. But it cannot blink, look away because it is embarrassed, follow your movement naturally or change its gaze because it suddenly noticed something behind you. The stillness becomes noticeable precisely because we expect movement. And the closer the face gets to looking alive, the more obvious the absence of life can become.

I think that the most fascinating thing about the uncanny valley is that it reveals something about ourselves. We are extraordinarily sensitive to human faces because faces are not just visual objects to us. They communicate identity, emotion, attention and intention. Our brains have spent a very long time learning the patterns that make a human face look and behave like a human face.

So when something comes along that looks almost human, those expectations switch on—which are ultimately not met with.

Maybe that is why dolls, mannequins, wax figures and digital humans have become such effective tools in horror. They occupy an unusual psychological territory close enough to activate our expectations of humanity, but different enough to violate them. A monster scares us because it is clearly not us. The uncanny scares us because something is *almost* us. And perhaps that is the real lesson of the uncanny valley. We do not necessarily fear the unfamiliar. Sometimes we fear the familiar when it becomes just unfamiliar enough to stop making sense.

Jamais Vu
FAMILIARITY REVERSED

By Jia Yadav

We have all heard of **déjà vu**, the unsettling feeling that you have lived through the present situation before. But what if the opposite happens? What if something you know suddenly feels... unfamiliar? This feeling is **jamais vu**.

Jamais vu is the sensation that something familiar suddenly feels completely new or strange. French for '*never seen*', it's perhaps best described as the opposite of **déjà vu**. You walk into your own room and for some reason, it feels like you've never seen it before. Or you're typing a completely normal word and after staring at it for too long, it starts looking suspiciously wrong (that happens a lot and ironically, I am a writer LOL). While it's less common, jamais vu is just as fascinating and complex as its more famous counterpart. So where did this bizarre little brain glitch come from?

Back in 1907, psychologist Margaret Floy , working with her student **Elizabeth Severance**, noticed something strange. When people stared at a word and repeated it again and again, the word could eventually start looking weird.

Washburn and **Severance** described this as a "loss of associative power".

Basically, the brain knew the word. It knew what the word meant. But somehow, the feeling that the word was *normal* started disappearing. Which sounds ridiculous until it happens to you.

More than a century later, researchers Akira O'Connor and Christopher Moulindecided to investigate this strange experience more systematically. Their experiment was surprisingly simple. Participants were asked to repeatedly write the same word again and again. At first, nothing dramatic happened They were just writing a word. But eventually, some participants began stopping because the word started to feel wrong. They

knew exactly what the word was, yet somehow it no longer felt like a word. But why does this happen?

One explanation is something called **semantic satiation** i.e, when you repeat something way too many times, your brain becomes so used to processing it that the meaning temporarily starts to fade into the background. Your brain can do something similar with words. When the same word is repeated again and again, the brain becomes extremely familiar with its sound and appearance. Eventually, that familiarity can become so automatic that the word temporarily loses its usual meaning. But it isn't just words. Jamais vu can happen with places, faces, music and even everyday routines. You might walk into a place you've been to a hundred times and suddenly see it differently. A familiar street can look strangely unfamiliar. A musician might momentarily lose their way in a piece of music they've played countless times. Even a familiar face can sometimes seem oddly strange when you stare at it for too long.

One interesting explanation is that our brains normally work with two things at once: recognising something and feeling familiar with it. Most of the time, these two processes line up perfectly. But sometimes, for a brief moment, those signals don't quite match. Your brain can still recognise something while the familiar feeling attached to it goes missing.

Researchers have even suggested that jamais vu might have a *purpose*.

Normally, familiarity is incredibly useful. It lets us do things automatically without stopping to think about every tiny detail. But ct as a kind of *reality check* for the brain.

There's also a fascinating phenomenon called **verbal transformation**, where repeating a word can make it start sounding like a completely different word.

There are also a few theories that explain the occurrence of **jamais vu**:

Memory-Recognition Disconnection: A key theory that points to a brief failure where the brain recognises something as familiar (memory) but isn't able to retrieve the feeling of familiarity (recognition), causing it to feel alien.

Attentional Focus: Hyper-focusing on a small detail can make the whole situation seem strange, as it disrupts normal perception.

Neurotransmitter Imbalance: Fluctuations in dopamine or serotonin

levels can interfere with memory retrieval and recognition processes.

But **jamais vu** isn't always just a harmless little "why does this word look weird?" moment. Similar disturbances in familiarity have also been reported in certain neurological conditions, including **temporal lobe epilepsy**, where changes in brain activity can affect memory and recognition. Experiences of unfamiliarity can also occur during some dissociative states. But for most everyday experiences, **jamais vu** is brief. It passes... and everything goes back to normal.

Most of the time, we move through life without thinking about how *strange familiarity actually is*. We see a familiar face and instantly know who it is. We walk into our homes without questioning where we are. We read thousands of words without stopping to wonder whether they are, in fact, real words. **Jamais vu**gives us a tiny glimpse behind the curtain. It reveals that this sense of familiarity is not as solid as it seems.

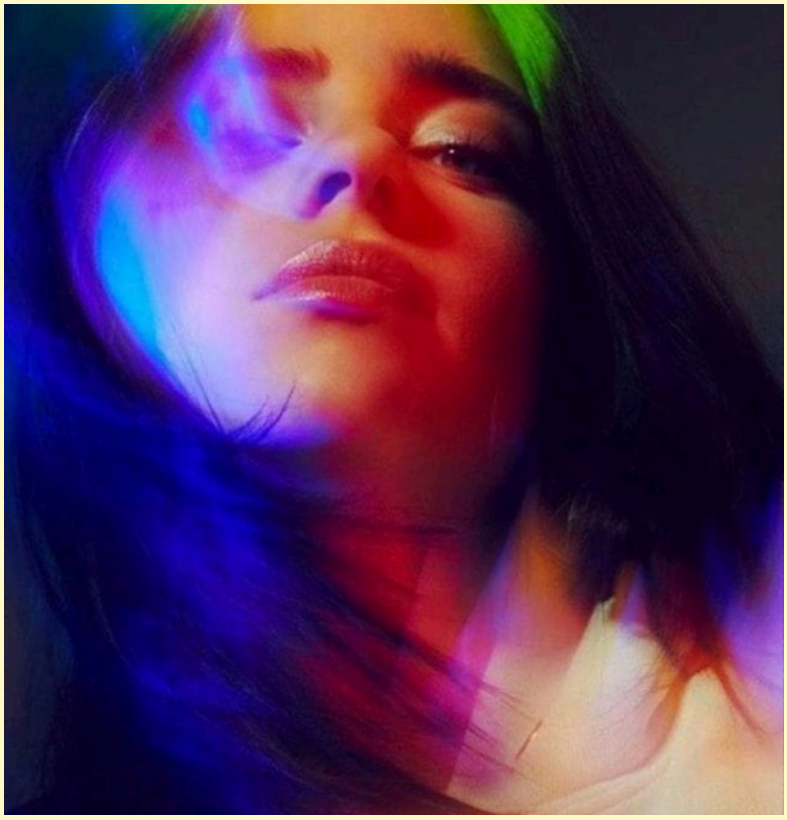
Jamais vu isn't a *malfunction*; it's just revealing how complex and strange human perception really is.

And maybe that's what makes it so cool, the idea that even in the most familiar spaces, your brain can still surprise you.

PERCEPTUAL ALCHEMY: *Synesthesia*

Living with a Sensorial Kaleidoscope

By Rishika Singhi



Imagine winning a Grammy and going down in music history—because every sound makes you see a different colour. Sounds like the plot for the next James Cameron sci-fi movie? Well, I imagine you'd be quite perturbed if I tell you that's exactly the case with Billie Eilish?

Yup. What Billie has is an intriguing neurological condition called *Synesthesia*, where experiencing stimulus in one of the five senses causes an involuntary, automatic experience in another sensory or cognitive pathway. Not an illness, just a really cool way some people's brains are wired.

About 1 to 4% of the global population experiences this. So yes, our beloved 'bad guy' singer is truly one in a million, but she's not the only one who experiences this. Some other examples include Billy Joel (getting some déjà vu from the name? That's because Olivia Rodrigo mentions him in, well, *deja vu*), Nikola Tesla (the AC part of AC/DC), Pharrell Williams and Franz Lizst among others.

The condition truly has some A-listers on its roster, be it legendary composers, singers or even scientists. However, synesthesia is not just some exclusive sound to color feature of your brain like your keyboard's text to speech. It affects multiple senses across its different types:

For the beloved musicians I just rambled about, it takes the form of *Chromesthesia*, causing sounds, music or even everyday noises trigger someone to see colours, shades or visual shapes. This, again, has two types of perception: *Associative Chromesthesia*, where one sees colors in their mind's eye; and *Projective Chromesthesia*, where one physically sees colors, shapes, or lines floating in the space in front of them. Fun Fact: Lorde, the multiple Grammy winning singer-songwriter once refused to work further on one of her now hit songs till she could have the initial chorus changed up, since the original one made her see a colour so rancid it made her physically ill.

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The phrase ‘auditory ipecac’ may not be just metaphorical after all.

Ever heard of a book that’s so well-written that it is called a “full course meal”? That tastes exactly how it sounds for authors like Sherrill Joseph, who has *Lexical-Gustatory Synesthesia*. In her words, her first name makes her literally taste a cherry lollipop! She even wrote the condition into one of her main characters. Apparently, a lot of people with this condition say that ‘Monday’ tastes like chocolate cake. Sounds wrong? Agreed.

On the other hand, moving on from letter palates to letter palettes, literature’s most famous synesthete, Vladimir Nabokov (the author of *Lolita*), discovered his condition: *Grapheme-colour Synesthesia*, at age 7, when he thought his alphabet blocks were all “painted the wrong colour”. He associated the English ‘A’ with weathered wood and the French ‘A’ with polished ebony, among others. According to his son, these experiences strongly influenced his rich literary metaphors and descriptions. The subtypes to this are *Associative-Synesthetes*, which, similar to the one in *Chromesthesia*, is perceiving the color with the mind’s eye; and *Projector-Synesthetes*, where the individual ‘sees’ the color projected in the physical world, like a printed page. Another interesting nugget of information about it is its key characteristics: it is consistent (color associations stay the same throughout a person’s life once they happen automatically), every one has a unique palette (my red might be your blue) and concept driven (association is made with the idea of a letter; font, size, or style do not affect it).

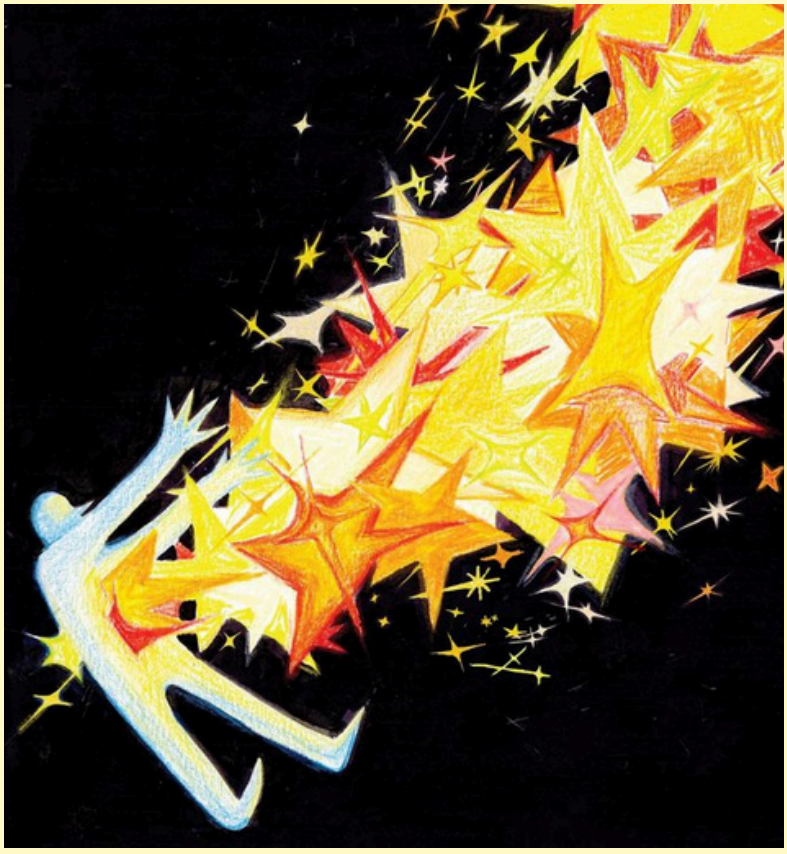
Then there’s *SSS*. No, I’m not talking about triangle congruency. SSS stands for *Spatial Sequence Synesthesia*, wherein people automatically and involuntarily see or feel numbers, months or days of the week in specific physical locations in space—nope, not the same as digits of pi floating around in the wrong order in the exam hall). Actor Geoffrey Rush, who is affected by *SSS*, describes visualizing time as “a series of hills and dales”. Key features include it being involuntary, with fixed positions (like 1990 feeling further than 2010) and mental maps (numbers or calendar units form an immersive 3D pattern, map, or loop around the person).

Other fascinating types are *Ordinal Linguistic Personification* (ordered sequences, like days of the week or numbers, are associated with specific genders or personalities. Like 3 being a bubbly woman or Thursday being a grumpy man that doesn’t like Saturday, a noisy puppy); and tactical manifestations of this condition (*Mirror-Touch Synesthesia*: seeing another person being touched causes you to physically feel that exact touch on your own body; and *Auditory-Tactile Synesthesia*: hearing specific sounds prompts a physical sensation on the skin, such as a tingling feeling.)

Wow. That *was* a sensory overload, eh? (I know I make good jokes.) It’s engrossing how the diversity in human perception can cause some people to live in *kaleidoscopes*—in every sense of the word (and well, if you don’t know what kaleidoscope means, Google it. I am *so* not going to ruin my perfectly poetic ending).

THE SCIENCE BEHIND *Butterflies*

By Rishika Rawka



CAUTION! Dear reader, please don't read the title and skip, thinking that suddenly, we've developed an interest in the butterfly as an organism and this is biological study on it. We're not talking about literal butterflies here. I promise, these 'butterflies' are the kind you will surely be interested in (author's word). Read on.

There are billions of people in this world. So why can *one particular person* walk into a room and suddenly make your heart race, your palms sweat, your stomach flip and your brain forget every sensible sentence you had prepared?

We call it 'butterflies' (told you you'd be interested). It sounds poetic—almost magical, like a tiny reminder that something about a particular moment matters to us more than we expected. But those butterflies are actually a fascinating conversation between your brain, your body and your emotions. Falling for someone isn't simply your heart 'choosing' a person. It is a complicated **psychological** and **biological process** in which attraction, anticipation, reward, fear, memory, excitement and attachment can all collide at once. And perhaps the strangest part is that the feeling of butterflies isn't exclusive to romantic attraction at all. You can get them before walking onto a stage, waiting for an important result, meeting someone intimidating, giving a presentation, going on a first date, opening an unexpected message, entering an unfamiliar place or even experiencing something thrilling that you have been looking forward to for weeks.The same fluttering sensation can appear when you're nervous, excited, scared, embarrassed or deeply emotionally invested in what is about to happen. In each of these situations, your body is responding to the possibility that something important is about to occur (priorities, people). And perhaps that is what makes butterflies so interesting: the person, situation, or event may not even have done anything yet. Your brain can create the feeling all by itself (*gasp* traitor!).

When Attraction Becomes a Reward

Think about the moment you see a notification from the person you like. Before you've even opened the message, you feel a tiny rush of excitement (cute). That anticipation matters because sometimes the feeling isn't produced by the interaction itself but by the *possibility* of what the interaction might bring. Romantic attraction activates the brain's **reward** and **motivation systems**. **Dopamine**, a **neurotransmitter** involved in **motivation**, **reward** and **learning**, plays an important role in this process. Your brain begins associating that person with **rewarding experiences**—attention, excitement, affection, laughter, comfort or simply the possibility of getting closer to them. Eventually, even a small reminder of that person can trigger anticipation because your brain has learned to connect them with something emotionally rewarding. This can create a fascinating cycle:

Person → anticipation → excitement → reward → wanting more.

Suddenly, checking your phone isn't just checking your phone. Your brain is looking for the possibility of a **reward**, wondering whether that person's name might appear on the screen or whether the next interaction might bring another moment of excitement. This is also one reason unpredictable **attention** can sometimes feel particularly powerful. When someone is sometimes affectionate, sometimes distant and sometimes unexpectedly attentive, each positive interaction may feel more significant because it is less predictable (keep them guessing).

he uncertainty can keep your attention focused on what might happen next, creating a constant anticipation of the next rewarding moment. So when you find yourself thinking, “Why am I checking my phone again?”, your *brain* (traitor x2) may have a better explanation than you think. It isn't necessarily because you have suddenly become incapable of putting your phone down; your brain has simply learned that this person might be connected to something rewarding, and anticipation itself can become part of the experience.

But Why Does Your Stomach Get Involved?

(“It has to.” “But—” “It just has to.”) Here's where things get even more interesting. Your brain doesn't keep emotions neatly inside your head. Strong emotional experiences can activate the sympathetic nervous system, which is involved in the body's “fight-or-flight” response. This system doesn't care whether the emotion is caused by love, fear, excitement, embarrassment or nervousness; when your brain senses that something important is happening or about to happen, your body can prepare itself for action. When you're around someone you're attracted to, your body may release adrenaline and other stress-related chemicals.

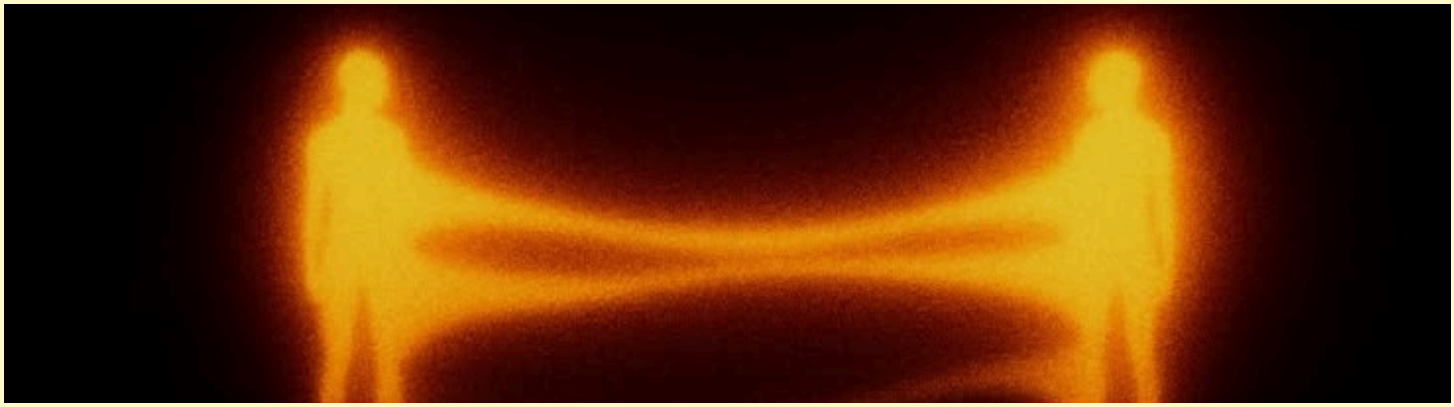
Your heart rate can increase, you may breathe faster, your palms can become sweaty and your muscles become more alert. The exact same system can become active before an important exam, a public speech, an audition, a competition, a difficult conversation or even a moment you've been anxiously waiting for. That is why the phrase ‘butterflies in your stomach’ isn't limited to romance(yeah, get your facts right).

You might feel them before stepping onto a stage because your brain knows that other people are about to watch you. You might feel them before opening an exam result because you don't know what you're going to see. You might feel them before meeting someone for the first time because your brain is preparing for an uncertain social situation. In all these moments, your body is essentially saying, “Pay attention. Something matters here.”

When someone becomes emotionally significant, the brain can begin giving them an unusual amount of attention, which means even ordinary things can suddenly remind you of them. A song, a place, a particular time of day, a phrase, a notification sound or something as simple as seeing their favourite food can bring them back into your thoughts. And uncertainty can make this even stronger. If you already know someone likes you, there may be less mystery, but if you're constantly wondering,And your **digestive system**? It temporarily becomes less important. When the body prepares itself for action, digestion can be temporarily altered as resources are directed toward systems needed for immediate action. That can contribute to the strange sensation of having a ‘fluttery’, hollow, tight or unsettled stomach. Sometimes it can feel almost as though your stomach has dropped, while at other times it feels like there are tiny wings moving around inside you. So those butterflies aren't completely imaginary. Your stomach isn't falling in love (LOL). Your **nervous system** is reacting to emotional excitement. Interestingly, the same physical sensation can accompany completely different emotions. Fear and excitement can both make your heart race. Nervousness and anticipation can both make your stomach flutter. Embarrassment and attraction can both make your face feel warm. The body doesn't always give emotions completely separate physical signatures, which is one reason we sometimes have to interpret what we're feeling by looking at the situation around us. The butterflies aren't necessarily telling you exactly what emotion you are experiencing; they are telling you that your body has recognised that something matters.

Why Can't You Stop Thinking About Them?

Ever had a crush so intense that the person somehow appears in your thoughts while you're studying, eating, trying to sleep or doing literally anything else? There is a psychological phenomenon associated with intense romantic attraction called **limerence** (trust me, we have solutions for everything—naming is just the beginning). Coined by psychologist *Dorothy Tennov*, the term describes an intense state of infatuation characterised by intrusive thoughts about another person, a strong desire for reciprocation and heightened sensitivity to signs that the other person may or may not feel the same way.



When someone becomes emotionally significant, the brain can begin giving them an unusual amount of attention, which means even ordinary things can suddenly remind you of them. A song, a place, a particular time of day, a phrase, a notification sound or something as simple as seeing their favourite food can bring them back into your thoughts. And uncertainty can make this even stronger. If you already know someone likes you, there may be less mystery, but if you're constantly wondering, *Did they mean something by that? Why did they reply like that? Do they actually like me? Why haven't they texted?*, your brain keeps returning to the unanswered question. Uncertainty gives the mind something to solve and humans are remarkably drawn to unfinished stories. When there is no clear answer, the brain can continue revisiting the same situation, searching for clues and trying to predict what might happen next. This isn't limited to romantic relationships either. We can experience a similar mental pull when waiting for an exam result, wondering whether we got selected for something, waiting for an important message or worrying about how someone interpreted something we said. The less certain we are about an emotionally important outcome, the more our attention may keep circling back to it.

The Halo Effect

There's another reason our crushes can seem almost impossibly perfect. When we like someone, we may start viewing their other qualities more positively too. This connects to the psychological concept of the halo effect—when a positive impression in one area influences how we perceive other characteristics. They're funny, so we assume they're kind. They're confident, so we assume they're intelligent. They remember one tiny detail about us, so suddenly we think they're incredibly thoughtful. A *single positive quality* can begin colouring the way we interpret everything else about them, sometimes before we have enough information to know whether those assumptions are actually true. Sometimes, we aren't simply discovering who someone is. *We're filling in the blanks*. This is why attraction can involve a certain amount of idealisation. We may see someone's best moments, imagine their intentions, remember the moments that made us feel good, and unconsciously construct a version of them that is partly based on reality and partly based on our own expectations. When we like someone, our perception doesn't necessarily become dishonest; it simply becomes *selective* (standards). We naturally pay more attention to the things that support the emotional story already forming in our minds.

Why Them?

This might be the biggest mystery of all. If attraction were purely biological, wouldn't we all fall for the same people? But we don't.

Our preferences are influenced by personality, experiences, familiarity, values, social environment, memories and individual expectations. What feels attractive or emotionally meaningful to one person might mean almost nothing to another. The **mere-exposure effect**, for example, suggests that repeated exposure to something or someone can increase familiarity and under certain circumstances, liking. That person you've seen every day for months may gradually start feeling more familiar—and familiarity can sometimes become comfort, while comfort can sometimes become attraction. We also tend to notice people who *fit* our ideas of what is interesting, attractive, safe, exciting or emotionally meaningful. Sometimes it isn't even one obvious quality that draws us toward someone. It can be the way they speak, the way they make us feel understood, their sense of humour, the confidence they carry, the familiarity of their personality or even something we cannot immediately explain. Past experiences can influence what feels comforting or exciting, while memories can shape the qualities we unconsciously look for in other people. In other words, falling in love isn't simply about finding the most attractive person in the room (though many may disagree—but it's okay. Priorities x2). It's about finding someone who becomes *psychologically significant* to you. Out of billions of people, one person can gradually become associated with a particular emotional world in your mind and once that happens, their presence can begin to feel different from everyone else's.

When Butterflies Become Something More

But butterflies aren't necessarily love. That distinction matters.

You can feel intense attraction toward someone without actually knowing them well. Passion can arrive before intimacy. Excitement can arrive before trust. Infatuation can exist before genuine compatibility has even been tested. The intensity of a feeling does not automatically tell us the depth or longevity of a relationship. Sometimes butterflies are simply the body's response to novelty and uncertainty, while *genuine love*requires time, understanding, trust, communication and shared experiences. As people spend more time together, something different can develop: **attachment**. **Attachment** involves emotional closeness, security, trust and the feeling that another person has become an important part of your life. **Hormones** and **neurochemicals** such as **oxytocin** and **vasopressin** have been associated with social bonding, although love is far too complex to be reduced to a single 'love hormone'. This is why long-term love may feel different from a first crush. The early stages can feel like fireworks—intense, unpredictable, impossible to ignore. Long-term attachment can feel more like home (#goals). The nervous excitement may become replaced or accompanied by comfort, familiarity, safety and the quiet s t

confidence that someone will still be there when the excitement of a new relationship fades. That doesn't necessarily mean the butterflies disappear forever; rather, the emotional experience can change as a relationship develops. Sometimes love is the racing heartbeat and sometimes it is the feeling of being able to breathe normally beside someone.

So, Are Butterflies Just Chemistry?

Not exactly. Chemistry explains part of the story. Psychology explains another part. Our experiences, memories, expectations, personalities and relationships fill in the rest. The butterflies are real, but they don't necessarily mean, “This is the person you're meant to be with.” And they don't always mean *love* at all. Sometimes they mean you're nervous. Sometimes you're excited. Sometimes you're afraid. Sometimes you're anticipating something important. In fact, one of the fascinating things about the human body is that excitement and anxiety can feel surprisingly similar because both can involve heightened physiological **arousal**. The difference often lies in how our brain interprets the situation. A racing heart before an exam can feel like fear, while a racing heart before a concert can feel like excitement, even though the body may be responding through many of the same systems.

The butterflies therefore aren't a perfect message from the universe and they aren't proof that something is destined to happen. They mean something much simpler: your brain has decided that this moment matters (traitor x3). And maybe that's what makes butterflies so fascinating. A person who was once a complete stranger can slowly become someone your brain searches for in a crowded room, someone whose message can change your mood, someone whose presence makes your nervous system react before you've even had time to think. The same nervous system can make your stomach flutter before you confess your feelings, before you step onto a stage, before you open an important result, before you meet someone new or before you take a risk that matters to you. We call it falling in love, feeling nervous, being excited or simply having a gut feeling. Science calls it **neural activity**, **hormones**, **reward**, **attachment**, **attention**, **arousal** and **emotion**.

But somewhere between the two explanations lies the experience we all recognise: the moment your brain says, “There. That one.” (traitor x349894)

MOVIE REVIEW: *Barbie*

By Kavya Bhatia

Barbie was all the rage in 2023. Hundreds of people went to theatres dressed in pink to watch Margot Robbie and Ryan Gosling enter the world of Barbieland. A world where every day is perfect. Until Barbie starts thinking about death. And suddenly, everything changes.

The movie begins in Barbieland, a perfect pink world where Barbies are doctors, lawyers, politicians and even the president. They can be anything they want to be. The Kens, on the other hand, live for Barbie's validation. But when stereotypical Barbie begins questioning her perfection, she is forced to leave her world and enter the Real World and Ken secretly joins her.

And that's when the plot changes.

The Real World is nothing like Barbieland. Barbie discovers what it means to be a woman in a world where women don't automatically hold positions of power. Ken, however, discovers patriarchy. He becomes fascinated by the idea that men can hold power just because they are men. When he returns to Barbieland, he transforms it into Kendom. The Barbies lose their independence and the Kens take control.

But beneath all the pink, parties and chaos, the movie is asking something much deeper. Who am I when the role I've always played is no longer enough?

When I first watched Barbie, I expected a fun, pink movie. And it was. The outfits, the music, the humour, Ryan Gosling's Ken. Everything was entertaining. But somewhere between the jokes and the ridiculously pink sets, I found myself thinking about things I hadn't expected to think. The thing that stayed with me wasn't the ending or even the plot. It was the idea that we spend so much of our lives trying to become the version of ourselves that everyone else expects us to be. Barbie is expected to be perfect. Ken is expected to be Barbie's boyfriend. Just like as students, we are expected to get excellent grades, maintain friendships, plan our futures and somehow remain completely unaffected by the stress of it all. So naturally, sometimes it feels like whatever we do, we are always failing one expectation while meeting another.

And that's what makes Barbie so relatable. You don't have to be a Barbie fan to understand what it feels like to question yourself, to feel like you're not enough, or to wonder who you are beyond the roles you've been given.

I would recommend this movie to anyone who wants something entertaining but also wants something to think about. It's funny, colourful and unexpectedly emotional. It makes you laugh, but then it asks questions that stay with you long after the movie ends.

Barbie may be a movie about a doll in a plastic house. But its central conflicts are surprisingly human. And perhaps that's the point. You don't have to be perfect. You don't even have to know exactly who you are. Because sometimes figuring it out is the whole journey.

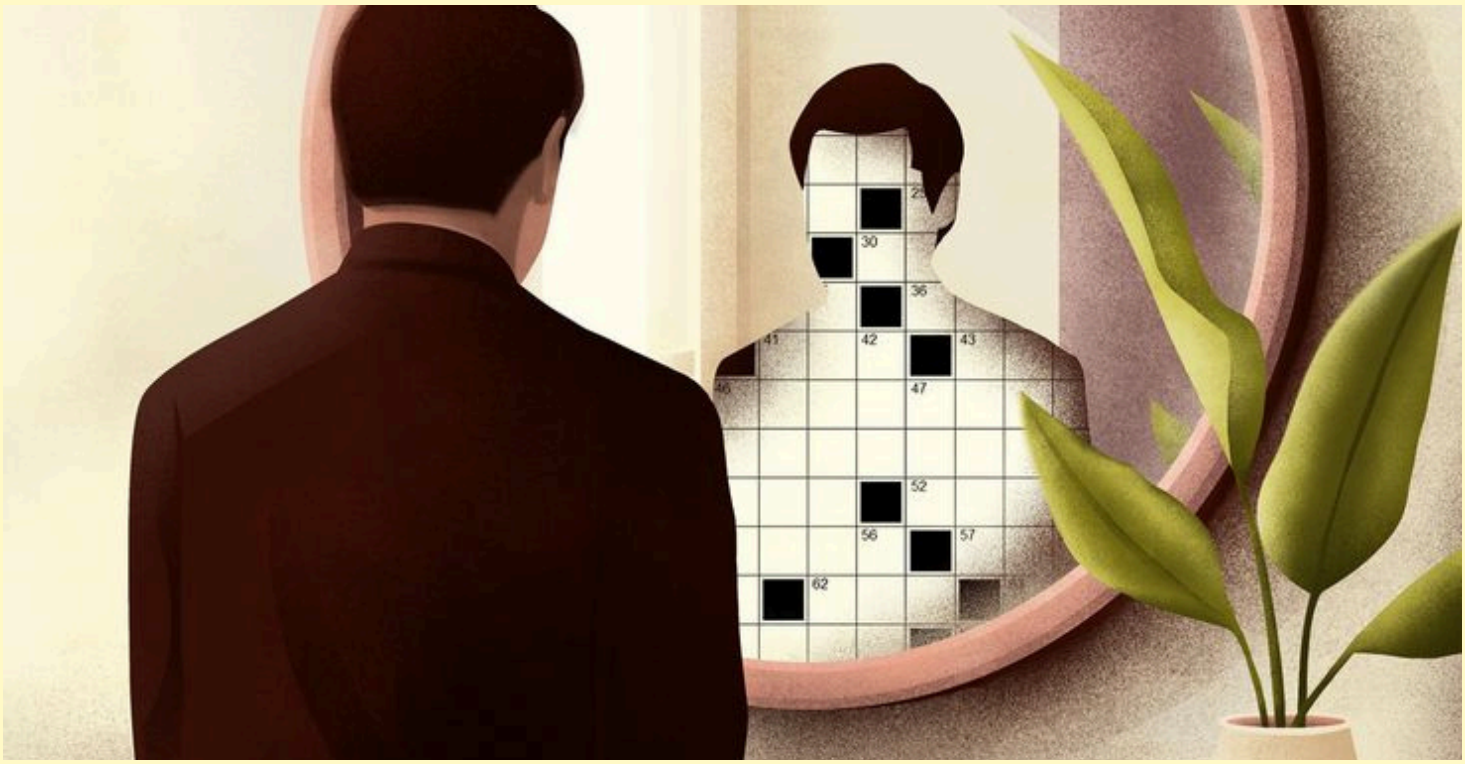
THE PEOPLE *Behind the Labels*

By Rishika Rawka

What do we see when we look at someone struggling with a mental illness or addiction? A patient, an addict, a person with schizophrenia, someone who hurts themselves or simply someone who needs to be treated? These are words we often use because they help us describe what is happening, but during our visit to a rehabilitation centre, I began to wonder whether, somewhere between the diagnosis and the treatment, we sometimes forget the person. Behind every diagnosis is a life, behind every addiction is a history and behind every symptom is an experience that we may never completely understand. Behind every person sitting in a rehabilitation centre is someone who once had dreams, relationships, fears, ambitions, memories and an identity that existed long before they were given a label. The visit made mental health feel very different from the way it appears in a textbook. Psychology is often introduced through definitions, symptoms, causes and treatments, where disorders become categories and behaviours become symptoms that can be identified and classified. But meeting people who have actually lived through these experiences makes one thing impossible to ignore: a human being can never be reduced to a diagnosis. A diagnosis may tell us something about what a person is experiencing, but it can never tell us everything about who that person is, what they have been through, what they have lost, what they hope for or what they may still become.

When Self-Worth Begins to Disappear

One of the stories that stayed with me was that of an elderly man who had begun to see himself as worthless. His feelings were deeply connected to his family and to the belief that he had failed to achieve anything meaningful in his life. He felt as though he had not accomplished enough and because of this, had gradually begun to see himself as a useless person. From the outside, such thoughts might seem irrational or even easy to dismiss. Someone might say that he had lived an entire life and that surely the experiences he had collected over all those years were achievements in themselves. But psychology reminds us that self-worth is not always determined by what we have objectively accomplished; it is also shaped by how we interpret our experiences, how we believe others perceive us and the stories we repeatedly tell ourselves about who we are. Sometimes, the most painful thoughts are not created by one single event but are built slowly through years of comparison, rejection, criticism, disappointment, loneliness or feeling as though we are not enough. When someone repeatedly begins to believe that they have failed, that belief can eventually stop feeling like a thought and start feeling like a fact. The person no longer simply thinks, “I haven't achieved enough.” They begin to think, “I am not enough.” Perhaps that was one of the most important things the visit made me realise: psychological suffering does not always look dramatic. Sometimes, it sounds like a quiet voice inside someone's head repeatedly telling them that they do not matter, that their life has not amounted to anything or that they have become a burden to the people around them. And when that voice is repeated often enough, it can become incredibly difficult to silence.



Fourteen and Addicted

Another story took me in a completely different direction. There was an elderly man who had begun using substances at the remarkably young age of fourteen. Fourteen is an age we usually associate with school, friendships, examinations, awkward teenage years, discovering new interests and slowly figuring out who we are, yet for him, substance use had already become a part of his life. Addiction is often spoken about as though it is simply a matter of poor decisions. People ask, “Why didn't they just stop?” or “Why did they start in the first place?”, as though addiction can be explained by a single choice. But addiction is considerably more complicated than that. What begins as experimentation, curiosity, peer influence, an attempt to escape emotional pain, or the desire to belong can gradually become something that affects behaviour, motivation, relationships, judgement, and the brain's reward system. Starting at fourteen makes his story even more striking because adolescence is a period of enormous psychological and neurological development

Young people are still developing the ability to regulate emotions, assess long-term consequences and resist impulses, while social acceptance and immediate rewards can carry enormous weight. This does not mean that every adolescent who experiments with substances will develop an addiction, but it reminds us that the circumstances surrounding early substance use matter. A fourteen-year-old struggling with addiction is not simply a person who made a bad decision; there may be an entire story of circumstances, influences, emotions, vulnerabilities and experiences behind that decision. Yet the most remarkable part of his story was not how his addiction began. It was how his life changed afterwards. He recovered and today he works at the very rehabilitation centre where people come for help. There is something almost poetic about that transformation. The person who once needed someone to help him find his way out of addiction eventually became someone who could stand beside others trying to find theirs. His past did not disappear, but it became part of a different story. His life challenged one of the most dangerous assumptions we can make about psychological difficulties: that a person's worst period is a prediction of their entire future. It isn't. Recovery does not erase what happened or mean that the struggle never existed; it means that the struggle does not have to be the final chapter. Perhaps that is what rehabilitation is ultimately about—not simply returning someone to the person they were before, but helping them discover that there can still be a meaningful life after the part that almost destroyed them.

When Reality Feels Different

Another experience introduced us to a very different side of psychological illness. We encountered an elderly man experiencing **schizophrenia** who believed that his mother communicated with him when he rubbed his fingers together and that he could hear her. To someone outside his experience, the belief might seem impossible to understand, but from a psychological perspective, what matters is recognising that **hallucinations** and **delusions** can feel extraordinarily real to the person experiencing them. It is easy to say, “That's not real,” but it is much harder—and much more compassionate—to understand that although something may not be objectively real, the experience itself is real to the person having it. **Schizophrenia** can involve disruptions in **perception**, **thought**, **emotion** and the interpretation of reality. A person may hear voices that others cannot hear or develop beliefs that seem completely convincing to them despite evidence that contradicts those beliefs.

Their experience of the world can become fundamentally different from ours. Two people can stand in the same room and experience completely different realities: for us, there may be silence, while for someone experiencing an auditory hallucination, there may be a voice; for us, there may be an ordinary movement of the fingers, while for that person, the movement may carry an entirely different meaning. Understanding this does not mean accepting every belief as fact. It means recognising the difference between disagreeing with someone's perception and dismissing the person experiencing it.

Treatment can challenge symptoms while still protecting someone's dignity, because the goal of psychological care should never be to make someone feel ashamed of what their mind is experiencing. Perhaps one of the most important lessons here is that compassion does not require us to experience the same reality as someone else; sometimes it simply requires us to acknowledge that their experience is real to them.

The Pain We Cannot Always See

Then there were the cases involving severe **self-harm**. Those were perhaps some of the most difficult experiences to process because **self-harm** can be so easily misunderstood by people who have never experienced such intense emotional distress. From the outside, a person may be asked, "Why would you do that to yourself?". But that question assumes that the behaviour makes sense only if the goal is to cause physical pain. Often, the psychological reality is much more complicated.

Self-harm can be associated with overwhelming emotional distress and can function, for some people, as an attempt to cope with feelings that seem impossible to express or control. It may become a way of externalising internal pain, regaining a sense of control, interrupting emotional numbness or communicating distress when words feel insufficient. This does not make self-harm a healthy coping mechanism—it can be extremely dangerous—but understanding its possible psychological function is important if we want to understand the person rather than simply condemn the behaviour. Someone who hurts themselves may be struggling with emotions that they do not know how to communicate and what appears confusing or frightening from the outside may represent an attempt, however harmful, to manage something that feels unbearable on the inside. Perhaps the most important lesson is that we should not confuse a coping mechanism with the person who developed it. The behaviour is something a person is experiencing or engaging in; it is not the entirety of who they are.

Beyond the Labels

These experiences made me think about how easily society separates people into categories: normal and abnormal, healthy and ill, functional and broken. But psychology exists partly to challenge such simplistic divisions. Human behaviour exists on a spectrum and mental health can change across different stages of life. A person can struggle immensely and still have moments of happiness. Someone can have a diagnosis and still have ambitions. Someone can experience addiction and still be a loving parent, friend, colleague, artist, student or mentor. A person who hears voices is still capable of experiencing affection, humour, memories and connection. Someone who has struggled with self-harm is still capable of growth and recovery. Someone who has spent years battling addiction can eventually become the person helping others fight the same battle. A diagnosis may explain something about a person, but it does not explain everything about them. Perhaps this is why the phrase 'the people behind the labels' feels so important. Labels can help professionals understand conditions and provide appropriate treatment, but when society begins to treat the label as the person's identity, we stop seeing the human being standing behind it.

What Rehabilitation Really Means

Our visit also made me think about what rehabilitation actually means. The word itself suggests rebuilding—helping someone regain abilities, confidence, independence, stability or a sense of purpose.

But rehabilitation is not simply about removing a symptom or making someone appear 'normal' again. It is about helping a person return to life, reconnect with themselves and discover that their identity can exist beyond the illness or behaviour that brought them there. The elderly man who once believed he was useless still had a story beyond his feelings of worthlessness. The man who began using substances at fourteen had a life beyond his addiction and his recovery eventually led him to help others. The man experiencing schizophrenia was more than the voices he heard and the beliefs he developed. The people who struggled with self-harm were more than the behaviours that had become visible manifestations of their pain. Perhaps what we saw at the rehabilitation centre was not a collection of illnesses but people trying to find themselves underneath them. Recovery can look different for everyone and it may not always be a straight or easy path but the possibility of change is what makes rehabilitation so meaningful. It reminds us that people are not permanently defined by the moment in which we meet them.

The Psychology We Cannot Learn From a Textbook

We often talk about mental health using statistics, diagnostic criteria, symptomsand treatment plans. These things are important because they allow psychologists to understand conditions, identify patterns and provide appropriate care. But there is another part of psychology that cannot always be captured in a textbook—the part that asks us to sit with another person's experience without immediately judging it, fixing it or reducing it to a label. Before someone became a patient, they were a person. Before someone became an addict, they were a child. Before someone received a diagnosis, they had an identity, relationships, memories and dreams. Before someone learned to cope through harmful behaviour, they were experiencing a pain that they may not have known how to express. The rehabilitation centre made these ideas feel less like definitions from a chapter and more like realities belonging to real human beings. It showed us that psychological disorders are not simply collections of symptoms written in a textbook; they are experiences that can affect someone's relationships, identity, choices, hopes and perception of themselves and the world around them. And understanding that difference is perhaps one of the first steps towards becoming more empathetic observers of human behaviour.

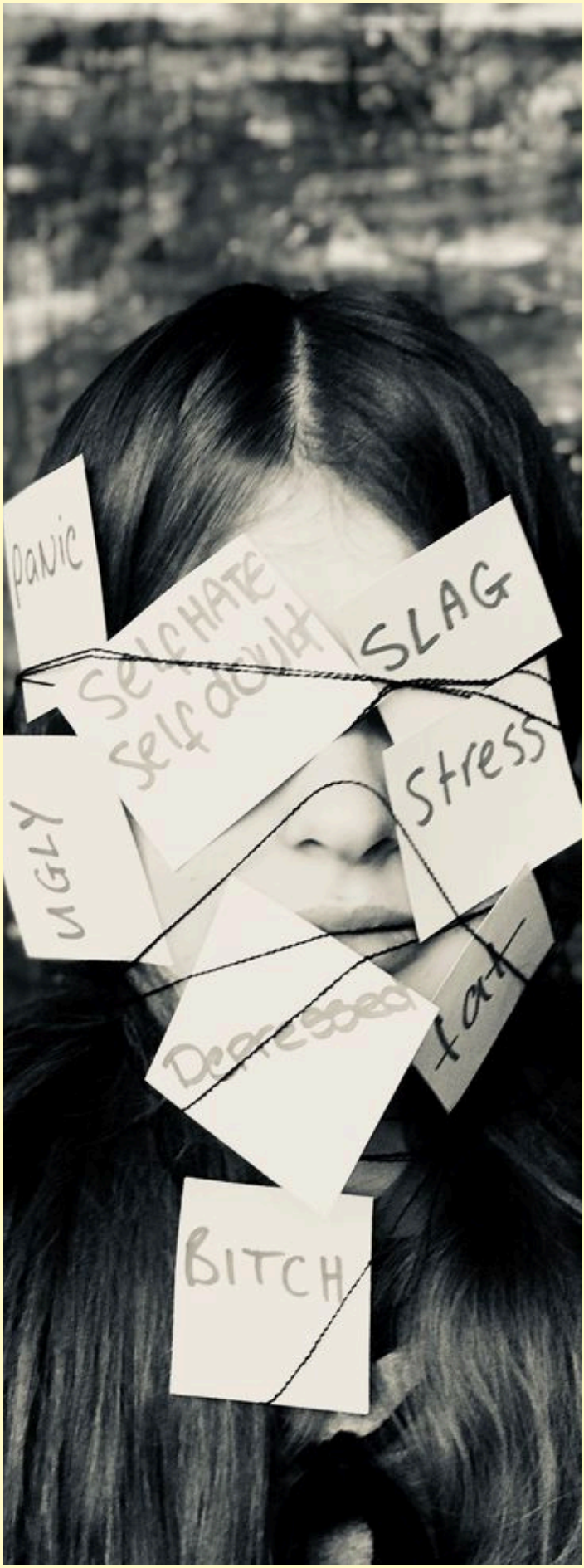
A Future Beyond the Diagnosis

Perhaps the greatest lesson from the visit was not about any particular disorder at all. It was about human possibility. The man who began using substances at fourteen eventually became someone who helps others recover. That single transformation is a reminder that people are not frozen at their lowest point. With support, treatment, time and sometimes extraordinary resilience, lives can change in directions that once seemed impossible. The person sitting in a rehabilitation centre today may not be the same person they become years from now, just as the man who now works there could not have known at fourteen what his future would eventually look like. His story does not erase the years of addiction,

nor does it suggest that recovery is simple or guaranteed but it proves that a person's past does not have to become a permanent definition of their future. Perhaps that is what makes human beings so difficult to put into categories: we are constantly changing, adapting, learning, healing and becoming. A diagnosis describes a moment or a condition; it does not predict the entirety of a life.

The Person Behind the Word

We went to the rehabilitation centre expecting to learn about mental illness. Instead, we learned something about people. We learned that a diagnosis can describe a condition but never a complete identity; that addiction can begin in childhood and still be followed by recovery; that a mind experiencing a different reality still deserves compassion; that emotional pain can sometimes emerge through behaviours we do not understand; that behind every label is a person whose story is far larger than the word written beside their name. Maybe the next time we hear the words addict, schizophrenic, self-harm or mentally ill, we should pause before imagining the label and try to imagine the person instead. There is always a person behind it—a person with a past, a person with pain, a person with relationships and memories, a person capable of change and most importantly, a person with possibilities. Because perhaps the most important thing psychology can teach us is not simply how to identify what is wrong with someone, but how to remember what is still human within them.



Behind every label is a life and a life is always more complicated, more painful, more beautiful and more hopeful than a single word could ever explain.

Gratitude Journal

WHAT IS IT AND HOW TO WRITE ONE

By Shambhavi Parmar

A gratitude journal is a personal diary where one writes what they are grateful for in life. It is one of the easiest habits anyone can start with; it helps one get distracted about what is happening in their lives. Unlike the regular diary where you write everything that happened in a day, the gratitude journal is about being appreciative of life's ups and downs.

The thought of keeping a gratitude journal has taken centre stage in recent times; this is because researchers say that it can help people with mindful reflection. It does not mean that one should be ignorant of their problems; instead, it helps individuals be more aware that life can be great even during tough times. This simple yet effective exercise helps one acknowledge that they are grateful for certain things in life.

What Is a Gratitude Journal?

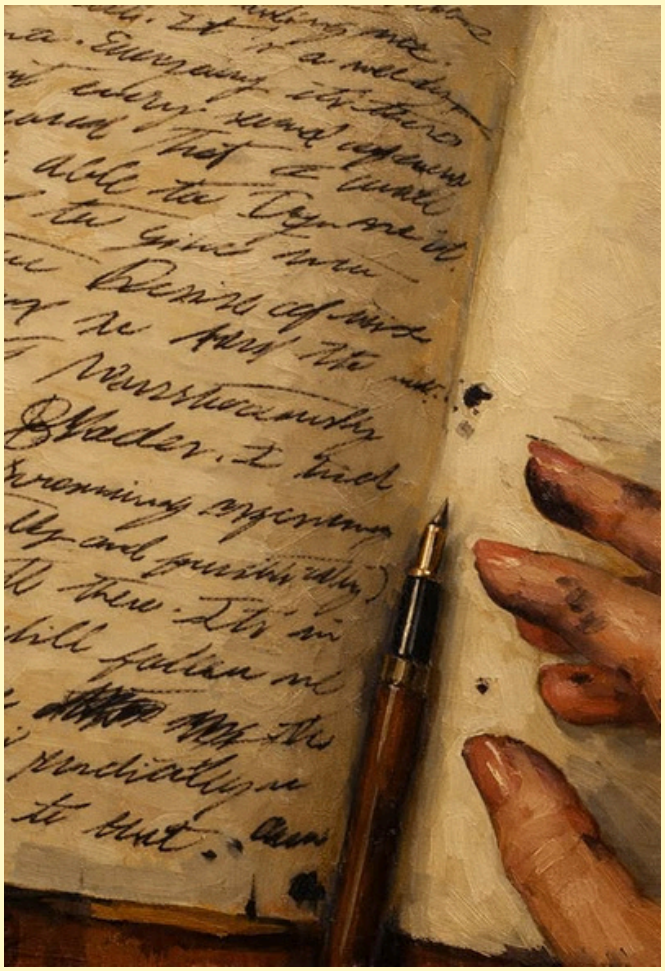
A gratitude journal is a notebook, diary, or journal where an individual writes down what they are grateful for in life. The entries can be about various things and/or people, including personal achievements, family bonding moments, and nice conversations with friends.

Every person's gratitude journal is unique in that it is based on their experiences. There is no hard or fast rule of writing when it comes to gratitude journaling; some people see it fit to write one sentence while others write paragraphs on their gratitude entries. The point is a person should find it easy and fun to document without putting too many restrictions.

When it comes to keeping a gratitude journal, the main objective is to have a personal journal where one can chronicle positive happenings in their lives.

How to Start a Gratitude Journal

Anyone can start a gratitude journal because there is almost no rule or guideline on how it should be done. All that one needs is a notebook or diary to chronicle their gratitude. For instance, picking a notebook or diary that you like using can make it more enjoyable. The first step is to find a suitable time to write in your gratitude journal.



It is always advisable to pick a time that is convenient and will not interfere with daily routines. The second thing to do is pick the date where the entries will be documented. After writing down the date, one should write about moments, feelings, or events that made them happy or grateful for the day. It is not enough to document things like family, friends, or success; instead, one should aim to write what happened that made them grateful.

How to Write Good Gratitude Entries

A good gratitude entry should be focused on specific instances rather than vague ideas.

This means that instead of writing down "I am grateful for my teacher", one should write "I am grateful that my teacher helped me understand this concept better.

Another way to make good entries is to ensure that one writes about multiple facets of life. Sometimes people are grateful for family, other times it can be about school, or even nature; this is a good way of making the journal more interesting. A good gratitude journal entry should always have vivid descriptions. Descriptions will jog your memory and help you recall what happened on that day.

What Can You Write About?

The most common question when starting a gratitude journal is about what one should write. The truth is there is no specific answer about what should or should not be written in a gratitude journal.

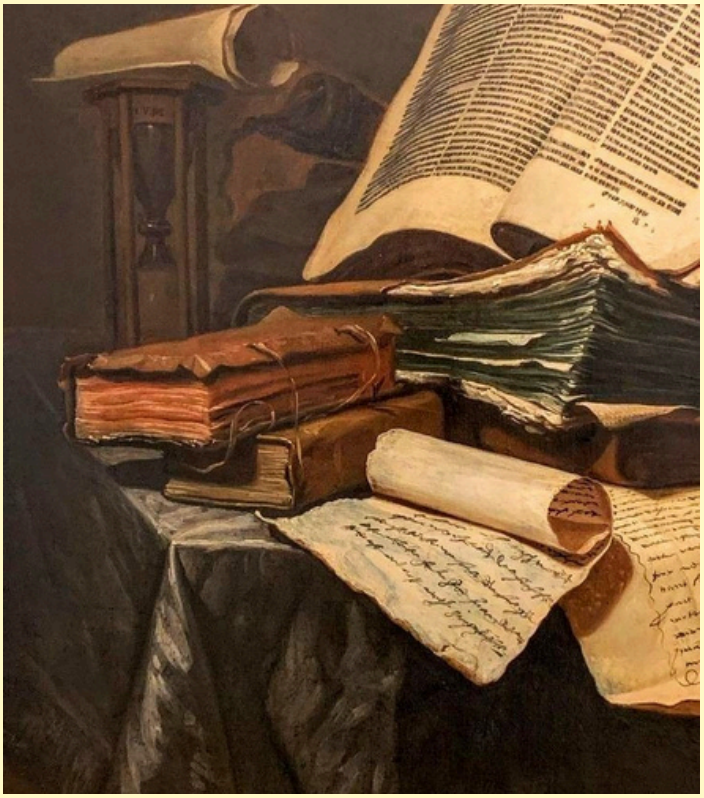
Anything that makes you feel good about life in general qualifies.

Some of the things that you can write about include showing appreciation to people in your life, such as parents, siblings, grandparents, teachers, and friends.

Nature is also a good thing to express gratitude for, including the rain, the hot days, the nice weather, and good-looking flowers and birds.

Gratitude journals can also entail simple accomplishments like completing a task, passing an exam, or presenting something new. It is always a good thing to acknowledge and appreciate simple joys in life. Things like family time, food, water, electricity, air, a good-looking room, music, or good sleep are all things worth writing about.

Gratitude journals can also be about challenging and painful events in life. For instance, one could write about how grateful they are for a lesson learned in life after experiencing a harsh situation.



Tips for Maintaining a Gratitude Journal

The most vital aspect of a gratitude journal is to practice honesty with yourself. Try not to overinflate things because you might feel disappointed later on. It is always advisable to refrain from using the same sentence structure when writing every day. If you are always grateful for the family, for instance, try to find specific reasons for being grateful instead of using the same sentence. Avoid getting stuck writing a lot or too long sentences when making entries into your journal. A good entry can sometimes be made by writing three simple sentences. Finally, always try to put pen to paper or fingertips to the keyboard every day. If something happens and you do not make an entry, it should not stop you from continuing.

Sample Gratitude Journal Entries

Below are a few examples of what can be written in a gratitude journal:

Example 1

Date: 12 September
Today I am grateful that my friend waited for me after school so that we could walk together. It made my stressful day better.

Example 2

Date: 15 September
I am grateful that I finally started understanding the Biology chapter after practicing. It was a lesson about patience.

Example 3

Date: 18 September
I am grateful for the lovely rainy weather today as it made the evening quite nice, and I enjoyed reading.

Example 4

Date: 21 September
I am grateful that my parents encourage me always, especially when I am not confident enough to do something. Their encouragement saw me pass my class test today.

Example 5
Date: 25 September I am grateful that I helped my classmate today with a question. It was a nice feeling seeing them smile after I assisted.

Gratitude Journal Prompts

Sometimes it can be quite challenging to think of what to write in the gratitude journal. In such a case, the following prompts can help:

What made me smile today?

Who helped me today, and am I grateful for them?

What am I grateful for today's learning?

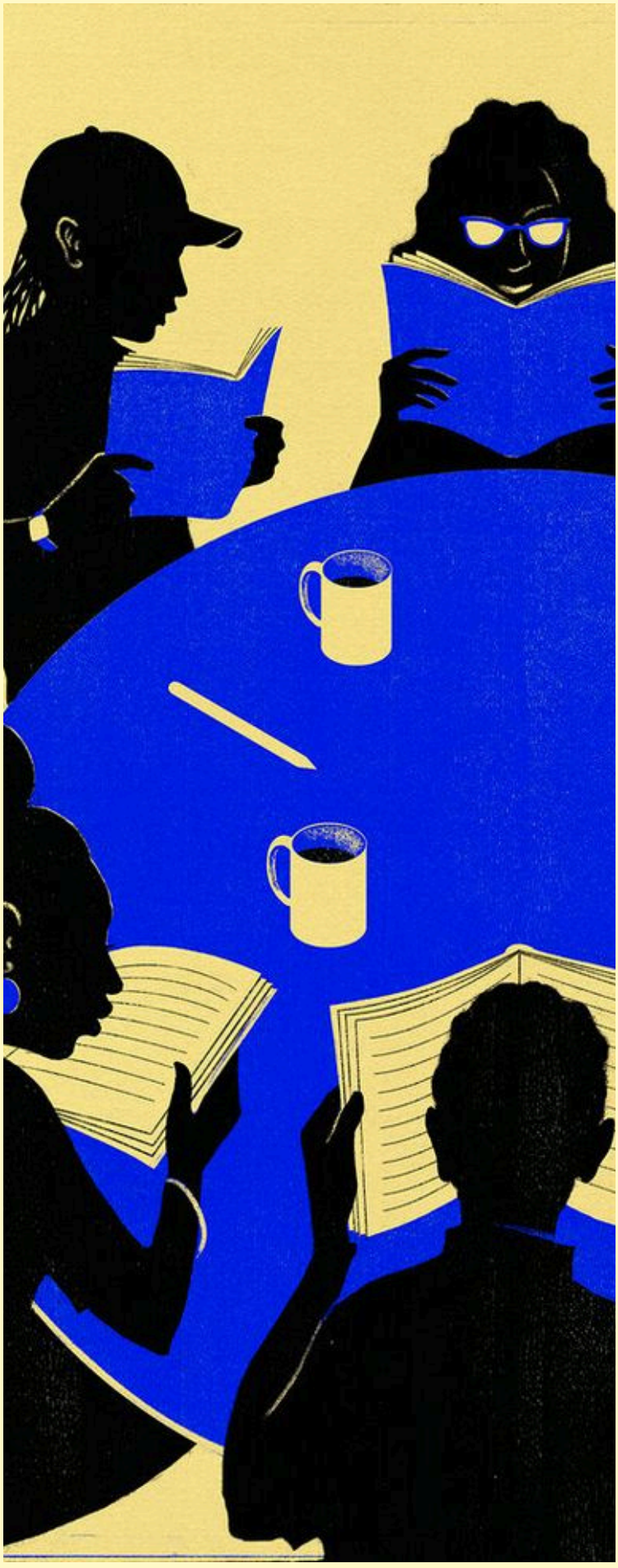
What simple comfort am I grateful for today?

What challenge made me learn a lesson?

What am I looking forward to tomorrow?

What am I grateful for about myself today?

What happened today that I will like to remember?



THE CASE STUDY OF *Vincent Van Gogh*

By Rishika Singhi

The truly creative mind in any field is no more than this: a human creature born abnormally, inhumanly, sensitive.
— Pearl S. Buck

Sigmund Freud viewed artistic temperament not as a natural gift, but as a defining characteristic of "the successful neurotic". Yes, you read that right. Freud viewed artistic expression as a specialized psychological response to unsatisfied unconscious desires and internal neurosis. He viewed 'sublimation' as the driving engine behind artistic temperament: diverting raw, socially unacceptable sexual or aggressive drives (libido) away from their original goals and transforms them into socially valued, beautiful expressions.

One testimony to this is an artist who remains a household name in the art world even after 136 years since his death at merely 37 years old, resulting from a life ending attempt with a gun. Vincent Willem Van Gogh.

The brush behind The Starry Night is infamous for cutting his left ear off with a razor after a fight with a fellow artist, an incident that in his words, was a "simple bout of craziness". But as psychology agrees, such an extreme action in emotional distress is never just a sudden spiral—it always has some built-up, underlying issues: He suffered from a multitude of disorders, illnesses and addiction.

A lot of his behavior is also attributed to his childhood. Gogh was born as a "replacement child"; the second born after the death of his parents' first born child. He was subjected to extremely high expectations, rigid moral standards by his pastor father and a perceived rejection and emotional distance from his mother. This, in accordance with attachment theory, contributed to an 'approval addiction', difficulty creating a separate identity and violent rebellion. Later failures in personal relationships resulted in periods of depression.

Van Gogh himself initially did not understand what was wrong with him. He wrote about a "mental or nervous fever or madness, I do not know quite what to say or how to name it" and initially—possibly to reassure himself, his friends and family—also of "a simple artist's bout of craziness".

His father wrote “he always has the inclination to melancholy”. From the age of twenty, he was described as gloomy, withdrawn and very focused on religious issues (including extreme displays of charitable selflessness). These behaviors went to such points that they contributed to him losing his job as an art dealer.

In following years, he showed a strict ascetic attitude and a very unhealthy lifestyle, often reporting of numbness, confusion and an intense, inexplicable feeling of fear. Meanwhile, he also displayed repeated instances of self-harm.

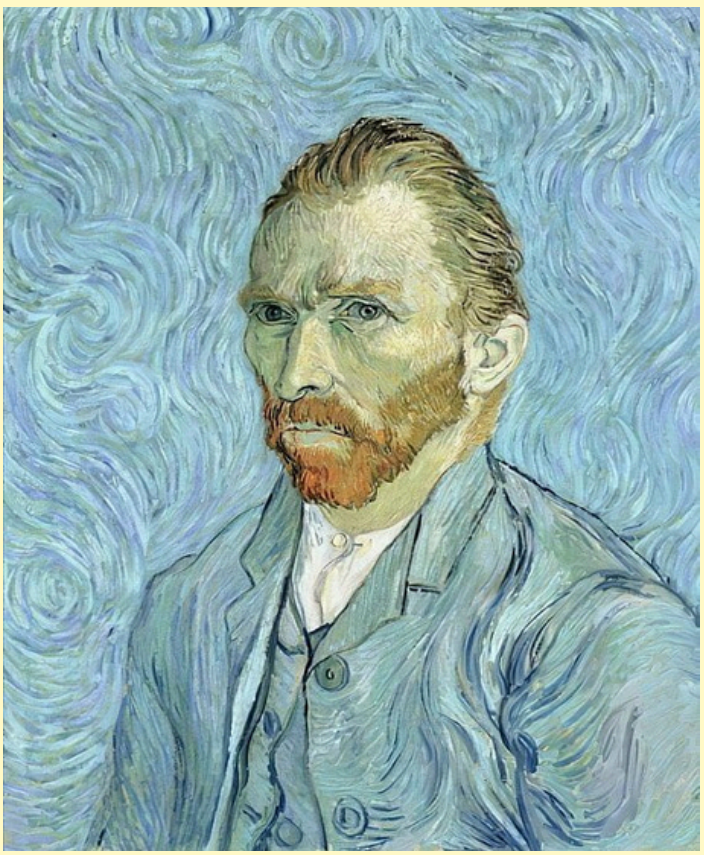
His working style was defined by an intense, rapid and deeply physical approach to painting, driven by an urgent need to translate his emotional reality directly onto the canvas, working in a “fury of work”, though he often turned to smoking and drinking in breaks as it “is the only thing that comforts and distracts” him. His frenzies of work were also accompanied by utter sleeplessness and a realisation of the alternating nature of his mental state. In one of his many letters, he wrote “I have a terrible clarity of mind at times, when nature is so lovely these days and then I’m no longer aware of myself and the painting comes to me as if in a dream. I am indeed somewhat fearful that that will have its reaction in melancholy when the bad season comes”.

His ill-famed self-mutilation happens after his fellow artist, Gauguin, decided to leave, a disagreement follows and Gogh redirected the aggression towards himself. This, was the start of his two year suffering with mental health, until his suicide, leaving behind a legacious 2100 artworks and the most compelling historical case of ‘mad genius’.

Bipolar Disorder

In many letters, van Gogh reported depressive symptoms and almost certainly suffered from several depressive episodes, with at least two major depressive episodes in Saint-Rémy, with also psychotic features in the first episode and with severe distress and dysfunction in both episodes. He also reported manic symptoms. Additionally, there were also periods with a decreased need for sleep and high, increased activity; though whether he also showed social dysfunction in these periods is not fully clear.

Although van Gogh showed mood swings and according to his brother,



Theo was as if he consisted of two conflicting personalities "the one marvellously gifted, sensitive and gentle and the other self-loving and unfeeling", the question remains whether the diagnostic threshold of a manic episode with social dysfunction has ever been exceeded at some point in its life, meaning that his episodes with manic symptoms were only hypomanic episodes. Thus, it is likely that Vincent van Gogh suffered from a bipolar disorder.

Personality Disorder

Van Gogh was unstable in his personal relationships, starting with his father and from then on with many other people in the different places where he lived, including his dearly beloved brother Theo.

Early on he exhibited solitary behaviour, while he also had a great need to meet the Christian duties of charity. He idealized family life, but he failed to marry and to found a family himself despite having several, although problematic, love affairs. Living with family or artists was the only alternative, but in both respects he was no ideal partner. He showed self-neglect and self-destructive behaviour (drinking too much alcohol combined with malnutrition), self-mutilation (the ear incident, possible self-poisoning and ultimately he committed a suicide attempt that resulted in his death).

This raises the question whether these mental problems were part of a personality disorder and more specific a borderline personality disorder, with a persistent pattern of instability of nterpersonal relationships,

the self-image and emotions and marked impulsivity, often combined with self-destructive behaviour such as suicidal behaviour or self-mutilation. There are also traits of an obsessive–compulsive personality disorder, however not in the compulsive, controlling sense but in the sense of a perseverative, rigid perfectionism.

Epilepsy

Van Gogh's doctors concluded that he had epilepsy at the asylum in Saint-Rémy, probably meaning 'épilepsie larvée mental'. This form of epilepsy is also called 'masked epilepsy', wherein a patient does not have classical seizures, but a behaviour disorder based on epileptic activity in the deeper brain structures. This diagnosis is nowadays called temporal lobe epilepsy or recently focal epilepsy with focal onset seizures, resulting in a highly variable expression of anxiety, delusions and hallucinations.

The Effect on His Art

In actuality, some experts actually say that Van Gogh's works are not products of his -,

mental suffering, rather, they were coping mechanisms. It became his therapy: his primary psychiatric remedy during his Saint-Rémy, where he used another cell as his studio and when he felt well enough, he was allowed to work outside the hospital, producing 150 works.

Fun Fact: his most recognisable work, The Starry Night, was also produced at this very asylum, in June 1889. This very work is now interpreted from a psychological perspective to high emotional turmoil, with its swirling, turbulent skies, lonely cypress trees and a hyper-animated perception of nature.

Other works of his, like Wheatfield with Cypress Trees with the ominous dark birds, dead-end paths and agitated brushstrokes is often viewed as a visual manifestation of profound isolation, despair and impending doom; while The Potato Eaters is a testament to his deep empathy—that later contributed to his intense Christian Charity and At Eternity's Gate, depicting an old man holding his head in despair, this work mirrors Van Gogh's own lifelong grief, weariness and existential pain.

In his final months, too, over a period of seventy days, he produced seventy-five paintings and over a hundred sketches and drawings. His works in 1889, the most turbulent year for him mentally and emotionally, featured brighter, eccentric color choices, often associated with documented periods of hallucinations and medical treatment.

Conclusion

Perhaps, then, the greatest tragedy of Vincent van Gogh is not that he was a 'mad genius', but that we have so often remembered the madness before the man.

No diagnosis can fully contain a life as complicated as his, nor can a medical label explain the strange beauty of The Starry Night, the tenderness of The Potato Eaters, or the quiet humanity scattered throughout his work. His suffering may have shaped the way he saw the world, but it was not the entirety of what he saw. There was also wonder, compassion, longing, hope and an almost desperate desire to find meaning in existence.

Van Gogh once wrote, "I am seeking. I am striving. I am in it with all my heart." Perhaps that is the simplest way to understand him—not as a man who painted because he was broken, but as a man who kept searching for light even while living through darkness. And perhaps that is why, more than a century later, his paintings still speak.

Maybe Van Gogh's greatest legacy, then, is not that suffering can create beauty. It is that even in the darkest seasons of a human life, the desire to create, to feel, and to keep searching for light can endure. And somewhere, beneath the swirling stars he painted, Vincent van Gogh remains—not merely a symbol of madness, but a reminder that even a wounded mind can still dream in colour.

The FIFA Fact

By Avani Soni

**Before you begin — It's over. I mean (with apologies for the dramatic beginning), Messi just retired from international football. In a way, it is something that doesn't affect just you and I. It affects the half a billion people living on this planet who have something to say about it. And that is precisely why I am writing this. Because this article alone has the power to represent half a billion people and their love for Lionel Messi. Please excuse me if you feel like I've turned this magazine into a personal fandom platform for Messi (hello, Ronaldo fans! *awkward cough*). But if not, welcome to the club, dear reader. This is in a way a tribute to Lionel Messi—to his legacy, to his achievements, to his humility and to football itself.*

Initially, I wanted to call this article 'Why Football is the Biggest Sport'. But it didn't feel quite right to me. Because while football is a class apart, sport in general has the ability to bring people together and create something that is worth treating as a global phenomenon. So while I *have* stressed on football (ahem, ahem), I have also (tried to) highlighted the effect of sport in general.

There is something wonderfully irrational (it's just perspective, people) about the human relationship with sport. We spend our lives navigating genuinely complicated problems—examinations, careers, relationships, money, politics, what to eat today (genuinely the hardest decision)—and yet millions of otherwise sensible people can be reduced to complete emotional chaos by twenty-two men running after a ball. A football match can make a person hug a stranger, cry in public, lose their voice, question the competence of an entire refereeing profession and within the same ninety minutes, experience the psychological equivalent of a minor earthquake. We say *we* won even though we were sitting on a sofa eating crisps (okay, fine, *chips* for the

fans of the American Dream). We say *we* lost even though our contribution to the evening consisted largely of shouting at the television (*I* shouted in the stadium—just thought I'd mention hehe). Somewhere between watching a sport and identifying with it, something fascinating happens: the game stops being merely entertainment and begins to become part of the self.

This is particularly striking in football. *Cristiano Ronaldo* has become the most-followed individual on Instagram, with approximately 680 million followers as of October 2026, while *Lionel Messi* has crossed the extraordinary threshold of 500 million, standing at roughly 517 million. To put that into perspective, Instagram itself has more followers than either footballer, but among individual human beings, these two athletes occupy an astonishing position at the summit of global attention. Their audiences are larger

than the populations of most countries and yet their primary occupation is, rather wonderfully, *putting a ball into a net*. The phenomenon becomes even more extraordinary when we look beyond individual celebrities: FIFA reported that approximately five billion people engaged with the 2022 World Cup, while the Argentina–France final *alone* reached close to 1.5 billion viewers worldwide (the world population is 8.3 billion, by the way). The question, therefore, is not simply why people enjoy football. The more interesting psychological question is *why* sport—and football in particular—has acquired the ability to occupy such an enormous emotional territory in the human mind.

The answer lies in the fact that sport satisfies several psychological needs at once. It gives us competition, but also belonging; uncertainty, but also structure; heroes, but also identification; emotional intensity, but within a controlled environment; and perhaps most importantly, a story that has a beginning, a crisis and an ending. Ordinary life rarely provides such neat narrative architecture. There is no referee to blow the whistle when an argument becomes unbearable, no scoreboard telling us whether we are succeeding at adulthood and certainly no VAR available to review questionable decisions in the last twenty four hours. Sport simplifies the world without making it meaningless. There are rules, there are opponents, there is something at stake and there will eventually be a result. For a few hours, the ambiguity of ordinary life gives way to a beautifully comprehensible question: Who will win?

Why We Need a Team to Belong To

One of the most powerful explanations for sporting fandom comes from **Social Identity Theory**, developed by *Henri Tajfel* and *John Turner*. The theory proposes that people derive part of their **self-concept** from the social groups to which they belong, meaning that membership in a group is not simply a social convenience but can become psychologically incorporated into our understanding of who we are. Sport provides an almost perfect environment for this process because it gives individuals ready-made groups with clear boundaries: Barcelona or Real Madrid, Argentina or Brazil, Manchester United or Manchester City, India or Pakistan. The categories are wonderfully *simple*, emotionally loaded and occasionally capable of ruining an otherwise perfectly pleasant family dinner (or starting World War 3, for that matter).

This explains one of the strangest linguistic habits in sport: the pronoun *"we."*Fans say, "We won," "We played terribly," "We need a new striker," or "We are going to win the World Cup," even though the closest most of us will ever come to professional football is an unfortunate school match and a disagreement over whether the ball was actually out. Yet the psychological phenomenon is genuine. Research on sports fandom has repeatedly connected team identification with self-esteem, group belonging and emotional responses to team performance. Fans can experience the success of their team vicariously because the boundary between the individual and the group becomes psychologically meaningful. This process can become even deeper through what psychologists call identity fusion, in which personal identity and group identity become so closely intertwined that the distinction between "me" and "my group" becomes unusually thin. A 2025 review in Frontiers in Psychology argues that identity fusion helps explain forms of sports loyalty that traditional social-identity approaches cannot fully capture, particularly the extraordinary emotional commitment and willingness to sacrifice that can appear among highly devoted supporters. The football club therefore becomes more than a source of entertainment; it can become a social home. The stadium becomes a place where thousands of individuals temporarily experience themselves as a single collective body, singing the same songs, wearing the same colours and responding to the same goal with what can only be described as coordinated psychological insanity.

Waiting for a Goal

Football has another advantage that is easy to overlook precisely because it is built into the structure of the game: goals are relatively rare. At first glance, this seems like a weakness. Basketball produces a constant stream of scoring, cricket can build tension over hours and tennis produces a continual sequence of points. Football, by comparison, can spend twenty minutes offering you absolutely nothing except a midfielder passing the ball sideways while everyone insists this is tactically significant.

Psychologically, however, scarcity can make an event more rewarding. Research exploring football from behavioural and neuroscientific perspectives has proposed that the sport's low-scoring and unpredictable nature may be particularly relevant to reward prediction error, the psychological mechanism through which the brain responds when

an outcome differs from what it expected. If we expect nothing to happen and suddenly a striker scores from thirty yards, the emotional impact is disproportionately large precisely because the event violates our prediction. The uncertainty keeps attention alive.

This is one reason a 1–0 football match can sometimes feel more suspenseful than a much higher-scoring game in another sport. Every goal has enormous informational and emotional value. At 0–0, everything remains possible; at 1–0, the entire psychological landscape changes; at 1–1, the narrative resets; and at 2–1 in the final minutes, millions of people begin negotiating with whatever higher power they happen to believe in. Football turns uncertainty into a sustained emotional experience, and humans are naturally drawn towards uncertain rewards because the possibility of an unexpected positive outcome can produce powerful anticipatory excitement.The game also provides something ordinary life often withholds: immediate feedback. A player makes a mistake and the consequences can arrive seconds later. A team succeeds and the scoreboard changes. The emotional relationship between action and outcome is therefore remarkably clear. That clarity may partly explain why sport can become such a compelling form of psychological escape.

The Football Match as Ritual

There is another dimension to fandom that is less obvious but perhaps even more interesting: ritual. Fans do not simply watch matches; they develop routines around them. They wear particular shirts, sit in particular places, watch with particular people, sing particular songs and repeat traditions that may have no rational relationship whatsoever to the eventual outcome. A person may genuinely believe that changing seats at half-time will somehow influence the performance of eleven professional athletes several thousand kilometres away, despite the fact that the players have absolutely no idea where the fan is sitting.

Yet ritual is not necessarily irrational in psychological terms. Ritual can create a sense of predictability, belonging and emotional regulation. Research into football fandom has suggested that matchday rituals can contribute to group bonding and may help regulate anxiety, particularly through collective participation and shared emotional experience. The ritual transforms spectatorship from passive consumption into participation. The fan does not simply watch the match; they prepare for it, anticipate it and experience it as a socially meaningful event. This is why a World Cup match can feel fundamentally different from watching an unrelated television programme. Millions of people may be doing the same thing simultaneously, but they are also aware that millions of others are doing it too. The result is a form of **collective attention**,

in which individual emotional responses become synchronised with those of a much larger community. When a goal is scored, the reaction is not private. It is multiplied across households, cafés, stadiums, streets and social-media feeds.

Why We Become Obsessed with People We Have Never Met

The psychology becomes even more fascinating when we move from teams to individual athletes. Why does someone we have never met become emotionally important to us? Why can a stranger's retirement produce genuine sadness? Part of the explanation lies in parasocial relationships, a concept used to describe the one-sided sense of familiarity or intimacy that audiences can develop with public figures. Athletes today are no longer visible only during matches. Through interviews, documentaries, Instagram posts, training videos and behind-the-scenes content, they appear repeatedly in the everyday lives of their audiences. Repeated exposure creates familiarity and familiarity can create attachment. Social media has intensified this process because it creates the impression that the athlete is not merely appearing before us but allowing us access to their personal world.

This helps explain why the emotional response to an athlete's retirement can be surprisingly profound. The fan is not necessarily grieving a personal relationship, because there was never a reciprocal relationship in the first place. Instead, they are losing a recurring psychological presence. The athlete may have accompanied the fan through school, adolescence, university, relationships, family changes and different stages of life. When the athlete retires, what disappears is not merely a sporting career but a familiar part of the fan's own autobiographical landscape (this became a little too personal...). This is also why nostalgia is so powerful in sport. A goal is rarely remembered as only a goal. It is remembered as where I was when I watched it. The shirt becomes associated with childhood; a tournament becomes associated with a particular summer; a player becomes associated with a particular version of ourselves. Sport therefore acts as a kind of

autobiographical memory trigger, attaching public events to private experiences. Years later, one goal can transport someone back to a room that no longer exists, a group of friends who have moved away or a version of themselves they can no longer quite recover.

Ronaldo and the Psychology of Greatness

(Surprise, surprise!) *Cristiano Ronaldo* offers one of the clearest examples of how an athlete can become psychologically larger than their sport. His appeal is not based solely on his footballing ability, because athletic excellence alone cannot explain an Instagram following approaching 680 million. Ronaldo has constructed a public identity around discipline, ambition, physical transformation, competitiveness and an almost theatrical refusal to accept decline.

Psychologically, this makes him an extraordinarily compelling figure because his narrative corresponds with the human attraction to **self-efficacy and mastery**: the belief that effort, competence and persistence can produce meaningful change. His body itself has become part of the story. He is not merely someone who possesses extraordinary ability; he presents himself as someone who has relentlessly worked to maximise it. For fans, therefore, Ronaldo can function as a symbolic representation of an idealised self — a person who refuses limitation and attempts to turn potential into achievement through discipline. His personality also provides something that psychologists studying celebrity and fandom repeatedly encounter: narrative coherence. Ronaldo's public story is easy to understand. A boy from Madeira becomes a global superstar through extraordinary ambition and relentless work. Whether or not real human development is ever quite so neat, the narrative is psychologically satisfying. It gives his success a cause and humans are natural storytellers who prefer meaningful explanations to random outcomes.

Ronaldo's enormous audience therefore makes sense when viewed not simply as a measure of popularity but as a measure of identification. People do not only admire what he can do; they admire what they believe he represents. To one person, he represents discipline; to another, confidence; to another, competitiveness; to another, the fantasy of transforming oneself completely. The footballer becomes a psychological symbol.

And Then There is Messi

(Obviously, I know that you knew it was coming.) If Ronaldo represents one form of sporting mythology, Lionel Messi represents another and perhaps this contrast explains why the Messi–Ronaldo debate has endured for so long. Ronaldo's public image has often been associated with visible ambition, physical excellence and self-conscious greatness; Messi's has been associated more strongly with mastery, creativity and apparent effortlessness. He seems, at his best, to do extraordinary things without appearing to announce that they are extraordinary.

That quality is psychologically fascinating because human beings are deeply attracted to perceived naturalness. We tend to interpret effortless performance as evidence of exceptional intrinsic ability, even when that apparent ease is the visible surface of thousands of hours of practice.

Messi's genius therefore carries an almost aesthetic quality. His dribbling, passing and spatial awareness can appear less like a demonstration of physical power and more like an intuitive understanding of the game itself.
His appeal, however, cannot be separated from the narrative of struggle that preceded his greatest international triumphs. Messi's relationship with Argentina was not always one of unconditional adoration. He spent years being compared with Diego Maradona and criticised for failing to reproduce his Barcelona brilliance with the national team. After the 2016 Copa América final, he even announced his temporary retirement from international football. His eventual transformation from a player questioned by his own country into the captain who led Argentina to Copa América titles and the 2022 World Cup created an unusually powerful narrative of *redemption*. Reuters' account of his farewell has described this evolution as a long, difficult process in which perseverance eventually transformed scepticism into national adoration.
That matters psychologically because humans are drawn to stories in which failure is followed by restoration. A perfect hero can be impressive, but an imperfect hero who suffers, persists and eventually succeeds can become emotionally meaningful. Messi's greatest achievement was therefore not simply lifting the World Cup; it was completing a story that millions of people had been following for years.

The Photograph that Became a Memory

When Messi lifted the World Cup in Qatar, the moment immediately became part of global popular culture. FIFA recorded that almost 1.5 billion people watched the final, while Messi's World Cup victory photograph became one of the defining social-media images of the event (that post is the most-liked post on Instagram, BTW). The importance of the image lies not simply in its popularity but in what it represented: the completion of a narrative.For fans, that photograph could function almost like a psychological closure point. The player who had once been criticised for not winning with Argentina had finally achieved the trophy that had become the central missing piece in his career. The emotional intensity came from anticipation accumulated over time. People were not reacting only to ninety minutes of football; they were reacting to years of previous disappointments, comparisons, defeats and expectations. This is one of sport's greatest powers: it allows a single moment to contain an entire history.

And that is precisely why Messi's international farewell in October 2026 carries significance beyond statistics. His final Argentina appearance against Benin at Buenos Aires' Monumental Stadium marked the closing of his two-decade international career and his 208th appearance for the national team. By the time this article is published, the match will already have happened and the familiar number 10 will no longer represent an unanswered question for Argentina. His international story has reached its final page.

Football Is Not the Only Sport that Knows the Human Mind

(The 'sport in general' I promised.) Yet if the FIFA Effect is really about the psychology of sport, football cannot be the entire argument. Other sports reveal the same human needs through different structures, and the contrasts are revealing.

Tennis, for example, transforms sport into a psychological duel. There is no teammate to absorb responsibility when confidence collapses and no tactical system that can completely conceal an individual's mental state. A tennis player must repeatedly confront the opponent and perhaps more importantly, confront themselves. Every point can become a miniature psychological contest involving anticipation, attention, frustration tolerance and emotional regulation. The great tennis comeback is therefore compelling because we are watching not simply a physical recovery but an apparent reconstruction of confidence in real time. The player who was losing five minutes ago must somehow persuade themselves that they can still win, while the opponent must cope with the sudden erosion of certainty. The result is almost a laboratory demonstration of momentum, pressure and **self-belief**.

Formula 1, meanwhile, offers a different psychological attraction: the fascination with speed, risk and precision. The FIA reported in 2025 that Formula 1 had reached a global fanbase of approximately 827 million, with 43% of its audience under 35 and 42% female, demonstrating how dramatically the sport has expanded beyond its traditional audience. F1 is particularly interesting because its spectacle combines human performance with technology. The driver is simultaneously an athlete, strategist

and risk manager, operating in an environment where tiny errors can have enormous consequences. The psychological appeal is therefore partly the pleasure of witnessing competence under extreme constraint. Add national rivalries, team politics, personalities, social media and the increasingly dramatic storytelling surrounding the sport—and F1 becomes more than a race; it becomes a narrative ecosystem in which engineering and human psychology constantly collide.

Why Football Became the World's Emotional Language

Most importantly, football offers multiple levels of identification simultaneously. A person can identify with a player, a club, a city, a country, a generation or even a particular style of play. Someone can admire Messi while supporting Real Madrid, love Ronaldo while supporting Argentina, follow a Premier League club while cheering for India in cricket and still somehow maintain the conviction that their sporting opinions are completely rational. Human identity is complicated enough to accommodate all of this. Football's greatest psychological advantage may therefore be *combination*. It is easy enough to understand that a child can follow it and complex enough that an expert can spend a lifetime analysing it. It is individual enough to create heroes and collective enough to create tribes. It is unpredictable enough to generate suspense but structured enough to produce meaningful narratives. It can be played almost anywhere, watched almost everywhere and discussed by almost everyone. Most importantly, football offers multiple levels of identification simultaneously. A person can identify with a player,

a club, a city, a country, a generation or even a particular style of play. Someone can admire Messi while supporting Real Madrid, love Ronaldo while supporting Argentina, follow a Premier League club while cheering for India in cricket and still somehow maintain the conviction that their sporting opinions are completely rational. Human identity is complicated enough to accommodate all of this.

The sport also gives us **controlled emotional arousal**. We experience fear without being physically endangered, aggression without necessarily acting violently, triumph without personally having accomplished the task and disappointment without the real-world consequences that normally accompany failure. Sport allows emotion to be rehearsed safely. It is one reason stadiums and matches can function as spaces of catharsis: feelings that have no obvious outlet in ordinary life can be expressed collectively. That does not mean fandom is always healthy. The same mechanisms that create belonging can produce hostility, out-group derogation and dysfunctional behaviour when identification

becomes extreme. Contemporary research continues to examine how strong group identities can create both **social cohesion**and **aggression**, particularly in highly competitive football environments. The psychological machinery that makes sport powerful is morally neutral; it can create community, but it can also create **tribalism**. The challenge is not to eliminate passion but to *understand* it.

The Last Page

By now, Lionel Messi's final Argentina appearance has passed and the photographs from the farewell will already be joining the archive of sporting memory. There will be no more international tournaments in which fans wait to see whether Argentina's number 10 can produce one more moment of magic. There will be no more arguments about whether this will finally be the tournament in which he wins the trophy. That particular question has already been answered. What remains is the legacy. And perhaps legacy is less about numbers than about what a person makes other people feel.

Messi leaves behind goals, assists, trophies, records and awards, but statistics cannot completely explain why hundreds of millions of people followed him, why an entire country eventually embraced him, or why a photograph of him holding a trophy could become a global cultural moment. Numbers tell us how much he achieved; they cannot quite tell us what it felt like to watch him.For one generation, Messi was part of the fandscape of growing up. He existed in childhood bedrooms, school conversations, football debates, television screens and increasingly, in the endlessly scrolling world of social media. His career accompanied the transition from one era of football to another, from television-dominated fandom to digital fandom, from the traditional football poster to the Instagram feed. His retirement from international football therefore closes more than a sporting career; it closes a cultural chapter.

There is something fitting about that chapter ending with Argentina, because Messi's international story was never simply about winning. It was about belonging. For years, he was perceived as someone who had achieved everything with his club but had not quite become Argentina's hero. He eventually did, not by escaping failure but by surviving it. His story became a reminder that public adoration is not always immediate, that greatness can be questioned and that sometimes a person's relationship with a group has to be built slowly through disappointment, persistence and time.

When he finally lifted the World Cup, the world saw a footballer holding a trophy. Argentina saw something more complicated: a player who had spent years trying to become part of a national story and had finally become inseparable from it.

(I did not cry while writing this. And I am lying.)

Perhaps that is the *real* **FIFA Effect**. Football does not become the world's biggest sport merely because it is easy to play or because its greatest players happen to be extraordinarily talented. It becomes powerful because it speaks to something fundamental in the human psyche. We are social creatures who seek belonging, narrative creatures who seek stories, competitive creatures who respond to uncertainty and reward and emotional creatures who attach meaning to people, places and rituals. Sport happens to gather all of these tendencies into one stadium.

We watch because we want to know who will win, but we return because the answer eventually becomes part of our memory. We support teams because we enjoy competition, but we stay because those teams become woven into our identities. We admire athletes because they are talented, but we remember them because they become symbols of qualities we recognise or aspire to in ourselves. A footballer can become a representation of discipline, courage, genius, resilience or hope; a match can become a family memory; a tournament can become the marker of an entire generation.

And eventually, every generation reaches the same uncomfortable realisation: the athletes who seemed permanent were never permanent at all.

Messi's international career is now over. Ronaldo's era, too, is approaching its twilight. The stadiums will remain, the clubs will continue, the competitions will return and another group of young players will eventually begin occupying the spaces once reserved for the legends we thought could never be replaced. A child who has never seen Messi play live will one day describe him as we describe players from an earlier age: through old footage, photographs and stories told by people who were there. That is how sport survives. Not through permanence, but through *inheritance*.One generation watches a player; the next generation watches the highlights; the generation after that hears the stories. The statistics become records, the records become history and history becomes nostalgia. Perhaps that is why sport has endured for so long. We do not love it merely because we love winning. We love it because it gives us something increasingly difficult to find in ordinary life: a moment in which millions of people can feel the same thing at the same time. For ninety minutes, strangers become a community; a player becomes a hero; a stadium becomes a memory; and a game becomes a story that may outlive everyone who watched it.

And perhaps, years from now, when another generation is arguing over another footballing genius, someone will inevitably ask what made Messi so special. There will be statistics to answer the question, trophies to count, records to compare and endless debates to resurrect, but none of them will quite capture the truth.

The truth is that Messi made football feel like something more than football. He made people stop and watch. He made children imitate him in streets and living rooms. He made opponents chase shadows. He made millions of people believe that, for a few seconds, the ordinary rules of movement could be suspended. And, eventually, he made half a billion people feel the strange sadness that arrives when something that has been part of their lives ffor years becomes part of their past.

His international career has now reached its final whistle, but the memories will

not obey it. That is the strange beauty of sport: the match ends, the player leaves, the crowd goes home, and yet something remains. A memory. A *feeling*. A story. A reason to gather again. The ball keeps rolling, long after the players who once chased it have disappeared from the field.

And perhaps that is the greatest thing sport gives us — *not the illusion that heroes last forever, but the privilege of having witnessed them while they did.*

And with that, I bring this rollercoaster journey to an end. Again, apologies for the Messi-centric approach, but again, it is beyond you and I. Messi is a very memorable someone in football. And in the columns of this magazine—my** magazine, our magazine—I wanted to preserve a little piece of it. But, it isn't the end. Messi may be retiring, but he sure has three backups—Thiago, Matteo and Ciro Messi.*

BOOK REVIEW

TUESDAYS with Morrie

By Jia Yadav

There is something intriguing about a book that is so simple. No complicated plot. No shocking plot twists. It is just an old professor and his former student sitting together every Tuesday and talking. And yet, somehow, Tuesdays with Morrie manages to leave you staring at the wall, reconsidering your whole life at 3 am.

Written by Mitch Albom, the book is based on Albom's relationship with his former college professor, Morrie Schwartz. The two had been very close during Mitch's college years. But after graduating, Mitch built the life he had once dreamed of—a successful career, money and a schedule so busy that slowing down no longer seemed like an option. Somewhere along the way, he lost touch with his professor.

Then he finds out Morrie is seriously ill. So he goes back. What follows is, in a way, Mitch's final class with his favorite professor.

What I liked most about the book is that Morrie never feels like a motivational speaker who has discovered the secret to happiness. He laughs. He cries openly. He gets frustrated. He admits his fears. Sometimes he even contradicts the image we have of what a 'wise teacher' is supposed to look like. And that is exactly what makes him believable.

This book does not pretend that reading it will suddenly fix your life. You will not finish the last page with all your existential questions answered (unfortunately there is no chapter called 'How to Figure Everything Out by Friday').

But the book does something more interesting. It makes you pause.

It makes you question whether the things currently stressing you out will actually matter years from now. And it makes you wonder whether you are spending so much time preparing to live your life that you occasionally forget to actually live it.
And if you have ever wondered whether you're spending your time on the things that truly matter, maybe you should give Morrie a Tuesday.

THE PAST THROUGH ROSE-Tinted Glasses

Romanticising Nostalgia

By Rishika Rawka

Have you ever looked at an old photograph and suddenly thought, “I wish I could go back”? Maybe it was a school year you once couldn't wait to finish. A friendship that no longer exists. A summer that seemed ordinary while you were living it. A person you thought you had moved on from. Somehow, when we look back, even the most ordinary moments can begin to feel golden. But here's the strange thing about nostalgia: the past we miss may not be exactly the past that happened. Our memories aren't recordings. They are *reconstructions*.

Every time we remember something, our brain retrieves pieces of information and rebuilds the event. That means memories can change over time. Details disappear, emotions shift and our present experiences can influence how we interpret what happened in the past. So when we say, “Those were the best days of my life,” are we remembering our past—or are we remembering our memory of the past?

Psychologists often describe nostalgia as a complex emotional experience containing both happiness and sadness. We remember something that made us feel good, but we also know we cannot experience it in exactly the same way again.

This is why nostalgia can feel strangely bittersweet. Think about an old song. You hear the first few seconds, and suddenly you're back in a classroom, sitting beside someone you haven't spoken to in years. You remember the jokes, the conversations, the feeling of that particular period of your life. But you probably don't remember every boring lesson, awkward moment, argument, stressful exam, or lonely afternoon. Our minds have a tendency to highlight emotionally meaningful moments. And that can make the past appear better than it actually was.

Social media can create a strange relationship with time because it allows us to repeatedly revisit carefully selected fragments of our lives. But photographs are also selective. We usually photograph birthdays, trips, celebrations, friendships, sunsets and happy moments, not the ordinary Tuesday when nothing happened. Our digital memories can therefore become an edited highlight reel of our lives.

Perhaps the deepest reason we romanticise the past is that we aren't only remembering events. We're remembering ourselves. Every stage of life contains a different version of us. The person you were three years ago had different fears, dreams, friendships, insecurities and expectations. Sometimes, nostalgia is a way of reconnecting with those forgotten versions of ourselves.

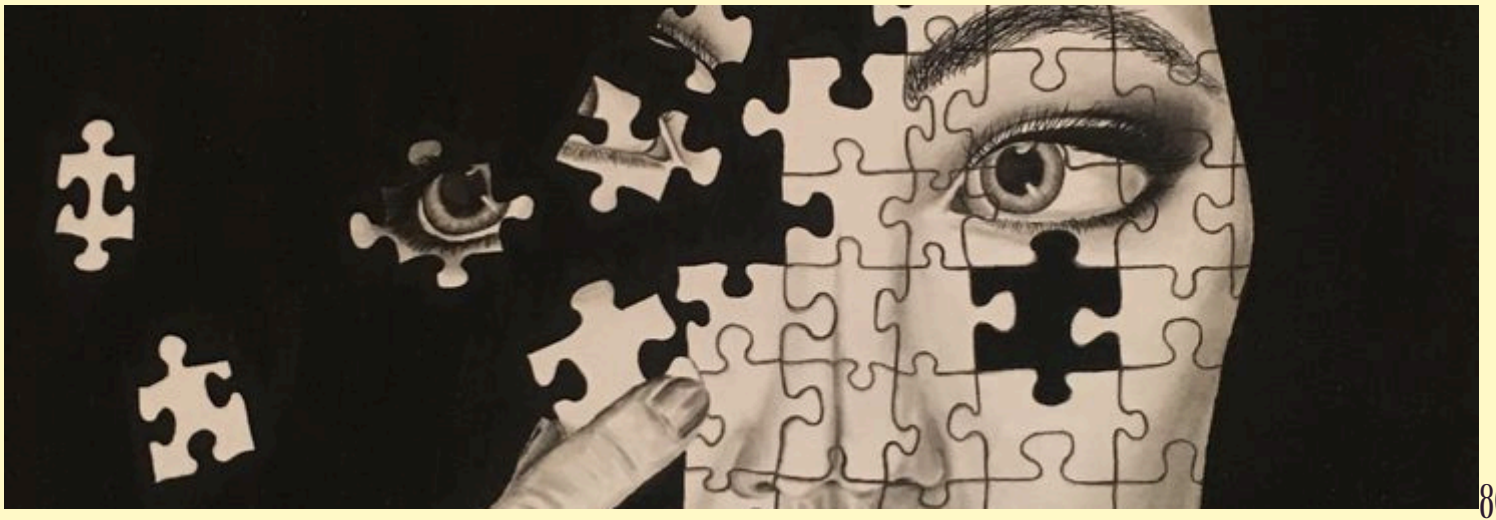
You might hear an old song and suddenly remember not only where you were—but who you were. And that can be both comforting and painful. Because growing up means constantly saying goodbye to versions of yourself that you can never completely return to.

So Should We Stop Romanticising the Past? Not necessarily. Nostalgia isn't automatically unhealthy. In fact, remembering meaningful experiences can help create a sense of continuity and identity. It can remind us where we've come from and what matters to us. The problem begins when nostalgia turns the past into a place we believe was perfect—and the present into a place we believe can never compare. Because the past wasn't perfect. You just experienced it without knowing it was the past.

There were probably moments you were desperate to escape. People you were annoyed with. Days you couldn't wait to end. Problems that felt enormous at the time. And yet, years later, you might miss that exact period. Maybe because while you were living it, you didn't realise you were collecting memories. That ordinary afternoon you barely noticed could someday become the moment you would give anything to experience again.

So perhaps the question isn't really: “Why was the past so much better?”
Maybe it's: “What did I have then that I need now?”

Because sometimes, nostalgia isn't asking us to go backwards. It's pointing towards something we want to bring forward.



One of the most fascinating things about human memory is that it is reconstructive. When we remember an event, we don't simply press ‘play’ on a perfect recording. We reconstruct it using fragments of what we experienced, what we currently believe and what we have learned since. This means that memories can become distorted. Maybe you remember your childhood as completely carefree, even though you undoubtedly had bad days. Maybe an old friendship now seems perfect even though you argued constantly at the time. The longer we move away from an experience, the easier it can become to smooth out its rough edges. The messy parts fade. The meaningful parts remain. And eventually, the past can begin to look almost cinematic.

This doesn't necessarily mean our brains are deliberately lying to us. Memory is selective for a reason. We tend to pay greater attention to emotionally significant experiences and positive memories can become particularly comforting when we're stressed, lonely or uncertain about the present. When life feels overwhelming, the brain may naturally search its memory for experiences associated with safety, familiarity, connection or happiness. That is one reason nostalgia can be emotionally useful. Remembering a time when you felt loved or belonged can temporarily remind you that you have experienced those feelings before. The past becomes a psychological comfort blanket.

Sometimes, we don't actually miss the past. We miss how we felt in the past. Maybe you don't miss a particular person—you miss the version of yourself that existed when they were around. This distinction is important. We often attach our emotions to people, places and periods of time, when what we truly long for is an emotional state. The past becomes a symbol for something we want in the present.

Nostalgia often becomes stronger during periods of transition. Graduating school. Moving cities. Losing a friendship. Starting college. Growing older. Leaving behind a familiar routine. When the present feels uncertain, the past can feel incredibly stable. You already know how that story ends. You know the people who were there. You know what those places looked like. You know who you were. The future, however, is full of unanswered questions. And the human brain doesn't always enjoy uncertainty. So sometimes, we look backwards because looking forwards feels frightening.

Today, we don't just remember the past—we are constantly being reminded of it. An old photograph appears in your gallery. A social media app shows you a memory from three years ago. A song you haven't heard since 2022 suddenly appears on your playlist. And within seconds, you're emotionally transported somewhere else.

MIND MAIL

(You send the questions. We do the overthinking. Everyone wins.)

Hi, people, I'm Avani, your Editor-in-Chief. I could talk endlessly about myself, so for your sake, I'll end the introduction here (*awkward laugh*).

Some initiatives become traditions and some traditions are eternal (dramatic much?). Obviously, I am referring to the Mind Mail. It's a means to communicate with us via the magic of technology. Send us requests (and we'll fulfill them — hello to the people who sent us Draco Malfoy requests), any articles you want to publish and any and every thought, theory or idea you think deserves to reach us.

And so as the torch passes on, so do traditions and so do ideas. So go ahead, dear reader — think. Think about all you can and all there is.

And when you're done, send it all. Right here.

From the depths of my heart,
Avani Soni
Editor-in-Chief (Mindscape)

THANK YOU

(from the bottom of our hearts)

We'll never get used to the feeling of creating a new edition. The ideas, the creativity, the excitement—everything feels like it's the first time all over again. And nothing compares to the joy of completing an edition, with many more to come.

Yes, of course, caffeine runs, TED talks, motivational speeches, hours and hours of coordination, abusing Google Docs and Canva and all that the internet has to offer—still the secret behind our success. And so we present Edition 5 to you.

Our deepest thanks to our Principal, Dr. Anju Chopra, for providing us with endless opportunities to present our ideas (ignoring the unhinged chaos in between that, of course). No words would ever be enough for our teacher, Ms. Priyanka Tiwari. Her enthusiasm, faith in us (even when we didn't have faith in ourselves) and constant encouragement brought us here today.

Thank you, Team *Mindscape*! Writers, editors and designers (future visionaries)—you are the spirit of this magazine. *Mindscape* reflects you—thoughts, ideas and values. Thank you for making it so beautiful.

And dear reader, thank you, thank you, thank you—for coming back (or coming for the first time). For sending all those ideas and requests through Mind Mail. For waiting for us patiently. For that constructive criticism and boundless appreciation. For constantly asking — "When is the next one due?" All that we do is for you. Until Edition 6.

With lots of love,
Team Mindscape

MINDS BEHIND MINDSCAPE

Ms. Priyanka Tiwari (Faculty Advisor)
The only adult in the room (thankfully). Watched the chaos unfold, chose not to panic, and gently steered us back every time we spiraled. Your faith in us was slightly concerning—but mostly appreciated.

Avani Soni (Grade 12)
Editor-in-Chief// Deadlines Fighter// Story Weaver Turned scattered ideas into something meaningful. Balanced creativity with chaos, deadlines with dreams — and built a magazine that feels like all of us.

Palak Kanal (Grade 12)
Head of Creative Design// Visual Therapist// Architect of Aesthetics Single-handedly prevented this magazine from looking like a school project gone wrong. Dealt with “make it look better” demands with zero context—and still delivered every time.

The Writers
Typed. Deleted. Rewrote. Questioned everything. Repeated. Avani Soni, Shambhavie Dubey, Jia Yadav, Shambhavi Parmar, Rishika Rawka, Rishika Singhi (editing), Shrushti Sharma (editing), Akshita Dwivedi, Maahi Sompurkar: The senior team. From emotional deep dives to “wait, this is actually good”—they carried this magazine on late-night thoughts and last-minute brilliance. Slightly unhinged, very talented. Nairity Rajput: The rising star. Talented weaver of words and brave enough to fight deadlines.

The Designers
The reason this doesn’t look like a badly formatted Google Doc.
Palak Kanal, Maahika Jhawar: Took pages of words, questionable formatting and last-minute edits—and turned them into something actually beautiful. Proof that design is, in fact, a form of magic. Nimiti Gupta, Khushi Mishra, Hiral Soni, Kaushiki Nigam: Design prodigies. Turning words into something worth looking at. Clean layouts, perfect fonts, and zero tolerance for visual chaos.